SCG Interlude: Stars Collide

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/72968591.

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General Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), Steven Universe (Cartoon)

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She-Ra, He-Man, Original Characters, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

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by TheInkredibleKaptainKaiju

Summary

Every story has a beginning. Some stories begin long, long before their seeming beginning. Eternia and Etheria, Homeworld and Earth, all things are connected. And all things flow toward climax.

Notes

Hi again! So, as the description says, this is a brief side-story to the She-Ra and the Crystal Gems series, since the next fic will most likely be the grand finale. I wanted to tie up some loose ends, as well as touch one some bits of character and lore that wouldn't really fit into the main story. Be prepared for some major revelations and some not-so-surprising callbacks, because here we go!

Chapter 1: Honor

She-Ra and the Crystal Gems Interlude: Stars Collide

Chapter One: Honor

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Castle Brightmoon was under attack: siege engines pounded against its doors, and catapults hurled fiery boulders against its walls. Citizens were rushed to safety as the invading army surrounded the sanctum, weapons in claws and tails at the ready. Hundreds of crimson-clad soldiers awaited their orders, prepared to take the kingdom.

Inside, the defending soldiers were woefully underprepared for this attack. Warriors with spears, swords, and bows stood at the ready for the moment when the doors would inevitably crumble, and the forces of the Fright Zone would storm inside. The weeks of constant fighting was about to come to an end; the dark king would reign supreme over the land.

But Brightmoon, and Etheria as a whole, had an ace up their sleeve. There was one final hope for the people, one last chance to defeat the invading forces. A warrior, brave and true, the only person powerful enough to fight them back. As destruction loomed, one thought was on everyone's minds: She-Ra would save them.

Down below the chaos, far beneath the war, a door to a hidden passage under the castle opened, letting a figure inside. "She's here!" an attendant said in hushed awe. "She-Ra has come back! Surely now we will…She-Ra…?"

Eight feet tall, clad in golden armor, She-Ra was always a sight to see. But something was wrong this time. As she stepped into the torchlight, the ones waiting for her saw that she was beaten and bloody, limping forwards as she held a wound over her torso. The

attendants helped her inside, where she slumped down against the wall.

The attendants were terrified, with the one who had spoken crouching down beside her. “S-She-Ra…?” she said again, in shock. “What is this? What’s happened!? How is this possible!?”

She-Ra coughed, blood dripping down from her lips. “Am… ambushed,” she said, her voice hoarse. “Skorpius’ men, they tracked me down, used some kind of magic…I fought them off, but before I could…” Somehow, they had gotten the better of her.

None of them had thought anyone could defeat She-Ra. The idea of her being this wounded was unthinkable. “Quickly, go and get help!” she shouted, and the other rushed off. The other woman remained by her side. “Don’t worry, we can help you! Just hold on a few moments, and you’ll be back on your feet! It’s still…it’s…”

“Razanna…” said She-Ra, placing her hand against the attendant’s face. “Thank you, but there’s no time. Even if I survive, I won’t be strong enough to stop King Skorpius’ forces. The only way for us to see tomorrow…” She picked up her weapon, holding it out to Razanna. “...is for you to take up my sword.”

“But…I…” She went silent, unable to fathom the very idea. “No, I can’t! You can’t die! And I’m not a warrior! You have to survive, please, you have to!”

She-Ra smiled. “I will,” she assured her. “My power, my essence, will flow into you. You will become the hero that Brightmoon needs–no, that I have always known you are.”

Despite her hesitation, Razanna took hold of the Sword of Protection’s hilt. She-Ra had been Etheria’s guardian for as long as she, as anyone, could remember. Nobody was really sure where she had come from, only that she fought to defend everyone who called this world home. “I…how can I become you?” she asked.

“Like this,” She-Ra said. “Hold the blade aloft.” The other woman did so. “Do you, Razanna, swear to fight to protect the people of

Etheria? To uphold the honor of Brightmoon, and to defeat evil wherever it may appear? To do everything you can to continue the legacy of the She-Ra?"

Razanna swallowed, her throat dry. "I do," she said hoarsely.

"What will you fight for?"

"For the Honor of Brightmoon."

Despite her wounds, She-Ra smiled. "Etheria is in good hands." She closed her eyes, and let herself relax. The moment Razanna had spoken those words, She-Ra's body began to dissolve into a million tiny motes of light, each of which began flowing towards the glowing jewel on the sword. Even though tears were flowing down her cheeks, Razanna held up the sword, feeling She-Ra's power, her very essence, being absorbed into the weapon.

She could hardly describe what this felt like. Not only was her body taking in the energy, but so was her soul. She and She-Ra were becoming intertwined, their beings one and the same so long as she held the Sword of protection. At last, the transfer was complete, and a glowing light overtook her form.

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Over the course of their siege, the forces of the Fright Zone had gradually been whittling away at Castle Brightmoon's defenses. The walls had been breached in a few key locations, letting some of their soldiers in. Brightmoon's defenders held them off as best they could, but very few of its warriors could stand against even a single scorpionkin, let alone an entire legion of them.

As the invaders tore their way through the castle's last line of defense, a beam of light ripped through the air down the hallway, throwing them against the far wall. A woman in purple with a crown on her head stood opposite them, preparing to fire another beam from her scepter when one of her attendants rushed over.

“Queen Illumina!” she said, exhausted from having run the whole way. “She-Ra has arrived, but…I think you had better see for yourself.”

The look of worry in her eyes spread to the queen. “What’s wrong?” she asked, immediately expecting the worst. “Was she…?” Just like her servants, Illumina could hardly fathom the idea of She-Ra being injured badly enough to warrant a ‘you had better see for yourself.’ She was invincible, what could possibly have caused this?

“My Queen…I’m here.” To the shock of both of them, She-Ra ascended the stairs to meet them–but she wasn’t exactly herself. She was the same size, wore the same armor, held the same sword, and had the same long, flowing hair. But it was obvious that she was different: her white hair and reddish, freckled complexion made that much clear.

“Razanna?” said Queen Illumina, befuddled. “Is that you? Are…are you She-Ra now?”

The woman in question took a moment to examine her new form. “Uh…yes, I believe I am. I wish I knew how to explain this, but she believed that I could take up her mantle, so I will do everything I can. I promised I would defend Brightmoon…and that is exactly what I will do!”

Illumina was uncertain. Razanna was untrained in even basic combat, and now she had the power of a demigod. Was letting her fight really a good idea? Before she could come to a decision, the front gates to Castle Brightmoon shuddered as a tremendous force from outside pounded against them. King Skorpius’ legions were at their door.

“If she chose you, and I trust in your abilities,” Illumina said. “You are our last hope, Razanna. Now, let us end this war!” She raised her staff, preparing to fire another beam.

The new She-Ra did the same with her sword. "I will not let her down…I will become the hero she knew I could be!" Her weapon likewise began to glow, the two lights swirling around and coalescing into one.

The door could hold on no longer, and finally exploded–from the inside, sending Fright Zone soldiers scattering to the winds. The familiar silhouette of She-Ra stepped out through the dust, Queen Illumina by her side. "Skorpius! This is where your tyranny ends! You will not take Brightmoon!" shouted the queen.

King Skorpius descended from atop his wheeled throne, his claws menacingly clicking, and his tail twitching in readiness to strike. "*Such* a pleasure to see you again after all these years, your majesty," he drawled, his gravelly voice dripping with venom. "And She-Ra…I don't believe I've ever had the honor of fighting you personally. I must say, I expected someone a bit more… impressive."

"Y-yeah? Well, just wait until you see me in action!" said Razanna, swinging her sword in what she hoped was an imposing manner, unable to believe she had just said that. "For the sake of the Kingdom of Brightmoon, and for all the free people of Etheria, I will defeat you!"

The tyrant scoffed. Shadows seemed to be drawn towards his figure, darkening the arena of their battle. "Is that so? I look forward to leaving Brightmoon's two defenders broken at my feet. Come, and meet your end!"

The pair shared a glance, steeling themselves for the coming battle. "It is you, your highness, who will be broken!" said the queen. "Come, She-Ra! Let us vanquish him!" The three combatants threw themselves at each other, clashing in an impressive display of power.

And that is how the legacy of She-Ra began.

Chapter 2: Power

Chapter Two: Power

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After ages of being divided into so many warring factions, Eternia had finally been united. Under the banner of a single warrior-king–D'vann Grayskull–would the planet finally know peace. Establishing Castle Grayskull to serve as the world's capital, D'vann ruled with the noble warrior, He-Man, at his side, bringing the greatest minds and fighters from across the lands to usher Eternia into a true golden age.

But, as such things tended to, this peace and prosperity was not to last. It all began as a well-meaning experiment in longevity, a union of magic and science that promised to change Eternia forever. And in many ways, it did. Chaos erupted. Buildings were torn apart. People and places alike were broken down to feed the singularity. Ultimately, the entire inner section of Castle Grayskull was sealed off by Eternia's greatest mages, sealing their former master within. But as anyone could tell you, great sorcerers, even ones who have lost their minds, cannot be held for long.

Rushing torrents of pure blackness tore through the streets, ripping through the cobblestone as easily as if it had been paper. The few citizens who remained inside desperately ran to safety, lest they too be caught up by the swarm. Just as one was about to be consumed, someone leapt down from the rooftops, driving their massive sword into the ground. The power of their impact split the stream of incoming black particles. "Go! I will protect you!" bellowed He-Man.

As Eternia's champion continued to fight off the clouds of shadowy dust, its king stood near the barrier, urging the civilians through an opening along with his soldiers. "This way! Hurry!" He shouted, clearly frantic despite remaining outwardly collected. There was only so much he could do against the abomination that

had once been his court magician–his friend. “I swear on my crown, I will not let this fiend destroy our home!”

All the while, He-Man continued to do battle with the nameless storm of dust. Even though it was devouring anything that fell within its great churning mass, making it into more of itself, the Sword of Power kept him from sharing this fate. “Great scourge! You will never take Castle Graskull! I would sooner drag you to the edge of darkness myself than allow this land to fall!” But despite his might, he didn’t seem to be doing any lasting damage to the entity.

D’vann scanned what remained of the town, searching for any remaining survivors. When it seemed like everyone left had evacuated, he hurried in to join the fray. “Get everyone to a safe distance!” he ordered his soldiers, taking a sword with him. Although he knew there was little chance of him putting up much of a fight against the entity, he had to try. He was the king, what else could he do?

At the center of the swirling mass, he could just barely make out a slender figure directing its movements. He got closer, and it grew clearer: a dark blue robe, nearly black, and its head hidden beneath a wide-brimmed hat. Seeing this was enough to make him pause, recognizing the person this used to be. Unfortunately, this gave the figure time to notice him, looking over with its red, diamond-shaped eyes.

A column of the black dust raced in his direction. D’vann raised his sword in defense, but this would not have helped–only He-Man rushing in and carrying him out of the way saved the king’s life. With neither of them anywhere to be seen after this attack, the figure emerged from the swarm to search for them.

The two of them were hidden within one of the nearby buildings, watching as its shadowed form passed by. “What are you doing here, my king?” asked He-Man, once it was safe to speak. “You were supposed to escape once everyone was safe!”

"Change of plans," D'vann said, peering outside. "A king never abandons his people–*or* his friends. I could not, in good conscience, leave either of you here alone."

He-Man looked away sadly. "Your majesty, your optimism is inspiring. But that thing…that isn't Gorpo anymore. He's been twisted by his creation, transformed into something else. I fear there is no saving him now."

In the back of his mind, D'vann knew this was true. "I understand. I'm prepared to do whatever I need to protect my kingdom. And I am grateful that you are willing to fight alongside me."

"Always, my king." Sword of Power in hand, He-Man steeled himself to go another round against the corrupted sorcerer. "He is nearly untouchable in this state, but if we can isolate his core–" Letting out a sharp cry of pain, he suddenly collapsed, holding himself up with his sword.

"He-Man!" King Grayskull rushed over to his side, helping him stand. "You're injured. Are you sure you are still able to fight?"

"Of course. I am He-Man! Master of–" He groaned, stumbling again. "No fleshwound will keep me from protecting the people of Eternia. Not even if I have to give my life…"

D'vann noticed a blackened spot on He-Man's side, with dark veins running outward from the wound. His physique would keep him alive for now, but before long, he would be consumed, and added to the swarm. "Giving your life would accomplish nothing. Even if you were somehow able to vanquish this threat, there will be others. Without He-Man, Eternia will never be safe."

Looking down at the scratch, He-Man realized he was right. He turned around, holding the hilt of his sword towards the king. "You're right. In that case, I must ensure that there will always be a He-Man."

Shocked by what this implied, D'vann stepped back. "You mean…?"

"You said it yourself: my death would accomplish nothing. This way, I can live on through everyone who wields this sword, my power protecting Castle Grayskull for generations." He-Man indicated the wound that his foe had dealt to him. "We both know I don't have much time left otherwise. Take up my sword, my king–I trust you."

Hesitantly, D'vann took the Sword of Power by the hilt. It was very heavy, as he expected, but not too heavy for him to lift. "What happens now?" he asked.

"Hold the blade aloft." King Grayskull did so. "Do you, King D'vann Grayskull, swear to fight to protect the people of Eternia? To fight with the power of Grayskull, and to vanquish evil wherever it may appear? And to do everything you can to continue the legacy of He-Man?"

"Yes. I do."

"Then everything you need is within you." As the sword began to glow, He-Man's form began to dissolve, breaking into a thousand tiny motes of light that flowed into the weapon's crystal. "The power is yours, my king."

"By the Power of Grayskull!" With a surge of energy like a lightning bolt, and a sound like the accompanying clap of thunder, D'vann Grayskull's body took in the essence of He-Man. Not merely channeling his energy, or thoughts and mind, he *was* He-Man. "I have the power!"

Needless to say, it would be nearly impossible for anyone to miss something like this, even from across town. And to the being who would soon be rechristened the Unnamed One, it was an irresistible beacon. The entity looked upon the building with its humanoid facade to see a single figure walking out; a towering titan wielding the Sword of Power.

King Grayskull and He-Man, intertwined and interconnected. “I once called you my friend,” he said, averting his eyes. “I wished that there was some chance of returning you to the person you once were. But now, for the sake of Grayskull, for all of Eternia, and for yourself…” He raised the Sword of Power, pointing it at his opponent. “You must be destroyed!”

The being melded back into the swirling mass of blackness, which rushed towards him in the form of twin tendrils. He-Man dashed forwards with impossible speed, his blade demolishing them like they were nothing, sending scattered particles raining down. There was only one chance to end this: he leapt high up into the air, before bringing his sword down on the center mass.

And that is how the legacy of He-Man began.

Chapter 3: Integrity

Chapter Three: Integrity

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And so, from then on, King D'vann Grayskull was more than just Eternia's ruler. He was its champion. The entity that had once been Gorpo, the Trollan who served as his court magician and close friend, had been defeated. Because its core could not be destroyed without endangering all life on the planet, it was instead launched into deep space, to forever linger in the cold and the dark, unable to hurt anyone anymore. The creation of Great Computers was outlawed, to prevent anything like this from happening again.

As the years went by, He-Man maintained his rule with honor and dignity. He was a wise and benevolent ruler, slow to throw his weight around, but willing to use the full extent of his powers, both physical and political, when his people were in danger. As such, by the time he had entered his twilight years, few individuals would dare threaten Eternia, especially Castle Grayskull.

Because of his connection to the Sword of Power, King Grayskull lived a long and healthy life. Even as his hair turned as gray as his name, and his physique faded, he did not succumb to any sort of deterioration. If anything, with less of a body to rely on, he honed his mind to compensate. A lifetime of ruling an entire planet meant he was well-suited to coordination and calculation.

As some might say, a little *too* well-suited.

"What must I do now?" lamented the king, seated on his throne. "I will not be able to protect Eternia forever. Even if the Sword of Power does find another suitable wielder, how can I be certain whoever that is will be up to the task?"

The throne room was largely empty, with only a single figure present aside from him. “You just need to have faith, my king,” said a small, impish figure, barely up to D’vann’s waist. He was currently tinkering with a small device of some sort. “The original He-Man trusted you to wield his power. And I’d say he was right to!”

“That was all fine and good at the time, Gwildor,” said King Grayskull. “Circumstances were dire enough that taking a risk was the only option. But now, my legacy faces ending not with a bang, but a whimper. So long as I can help it, I refuse to let Eternia be placed in the hands of mere chance. No, I must have assurance that my successor will not fail!”

“That’s quite a cavalier way to talk about your son, sire,” said Gwildor. “Sure, the boy may be a bit unsure of himself, but that’s hardly reason to doubt his capabilities. I’ve seen him in action, and he’s a fine swordsman and skilled negotiator.”

King Grayskull nodded silently. “I have no doubt of his abilities as a king and a warrior. Once I am gone, he will lead Eternia just as well as I have, if not better. But entrusting him with the Sword of Power…” He looked over at the sword, which had been hung on the wall behind a layer of glass. None could remove it aside from him, as it was coded to his specific DNA. Gwildor had designed that mechanism himself. “I worry such a burden will be too much for him to bear.”

“Ah. I see exactly what this is.” Gwildor smiled knowingly. “Sire, it’s entirely natural for fathers to worry about their sons. I imagine you want him to live the best life he possibly can, yes? But you can’t do that if you live his life for him. He’ll only be able to truly fly if he’s allowed to leave the nest.”

The king pondered this for a while. “And yet…if I were not there should something happen to him, I would never forgive myself. If only there was a way I could stay with him, always ready to act, while still allowing him to–” He suddenly stood up from his throne.

"That's it! Gwildor, my body is old and frail, right? Then all we need to do is make a new one!"

Gwildor was uneasy at this idea. "Sire, might I remind you that cloning is against the law? A law *you* created, I might add. A king cannot just change the rules every time he sees fit!"

Technically, he could, but Grayskull would rather avoid stooping to that level. "That is because of the ethics of creating life," he said. "But if the clone was nothing more than an empty vessel, a place to store my consciousness, then there would be no moral implications! Gwildor, you are one of the greatest engineers Eternia has ever known–I know you can figure this out."

Of course he could, but that wasn't the problem here. If D'vann had one fatal flaw, it was how stubborn he could be. His refusal to ever give in had saved the day more times than Gwildor could count…and the day had needed saving *from* almost as often. "Of course, sire. But I must strongly suggest that you–"

"Excellent. I expect the procedure to be completed in time for my son's coronation. We all have to look our best, after all!" He sat back down on his throne. "Any resources you need, you will have."

Bowing, Gwildor then made his exit. "I won't disappoint you, King Grayskull." As he left the throne room, a sadness he had been hiding caused his body to sag. D'vann was a good man, he wouldn't say otherwise. But if there were two things that could really change a person, it was love, and unchecked power. And the king had no shortage of either.

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The courtyard of Castle Grayskull was buzzing with excitement. Nearly everyone in the kingdom had arrived, crowding around the stands to watch the transfer of power. Many were just as anxious as they were joyous, as many wondered if Prince Wun-Dar could truly live up to his father's legacy. But considering that King D'vann had all but single-handedly united the various factions of

Eternia under one banner, ending centuries of war, that was nearly an impossible feat.

A hush came over the crowd as the prince approached the raised platform where the king stood. He was the spitting image of his father–almost literally. Even though he was not even two decades of age, his rugged body was covered in scars and a thick layer of facial hair. It was no wonder that the populace had taken to calling him 'Wun-Dar the Savage,' and it was not just for his relentless fighting style.

But not all eyes were on the prince that day. Many people were staring at King Grayskull, and not just because they were sad to see him leaving the throne. Rumors had been swirling around, rumors that the king had found some way to make himself younger. Theories ranged from fountains of youth, to shady deals with evil spirits, to unknown abilities of the Sword of Power. Whether or not any of these were true, he definitely looked much younger than he previously had. By thirty years, at least.

D'vann stood proudly on the podium, watching as his son approached, taking his place at his side. "Friends, subjects…today, we witness the dawn of a new king's reign! For these past years, I have watched Eternia grow beyond even what I could have imagined. In one generation, we have gone from a world ravaged by war, to a utopia where peace rules supreme, where science and magic have united to create something truly beautiful. As I look upon this paradise, I realize that it was you, the good people of Eternia, who made it all possible. And now that we no longer have a need for war, we have no need for a wartime king. And as such…I feel that this is the perfect time to pass the crown to my son."

Rather than his crown, he took the Sword of Power out from its strap on his back, holding it out to Prince Wun-Dar. The soon-to-be king gently but firmly took it by the handle, hoisting it over his head. "By the Power of Grayskull!" Energy surged through him… and all told, he didn't look much different as He-Man. Just a bit

taller, and wearing new armor. His beard was also braided, but that was about it.

"People of Eternia, I give you your new He-Man: King Wun-Dar Grayskull!" The crowd erupted into cheers, and father and son both looked out proudly on their subjects. Wun-Dar couldn't resist showboating a little, twirling the sword around and throwing it up into the air. It seemed that, at least for now, everyone's doubts about the new king were assuaged, as were the rumors about the old king. A fickle bunch, it seemed.

From within one of the courtyard's tunnels, Gwildor watched the celebration with hesitance. Once again, one of his creations had been successful. But for the first time in his life, he wasn't sure if that would be a good or a bad thing. He had known Wun-Dar for the boy's entire life–despite being a bit rough around the edges, he knew he possessed a strong moral compass. It wasn't his kingship that worried him.

No, it was D'vann he was worried about. He knew that this whole ordeal was set in motion by how much he cared about his family and his people. That much was never in question. But as he turned away to walk back to his laboratory, one thought was on his mind. King Grayskull–the *former* King Grayskull–had insisted that what he was doing was for the good of Eternia.

That was exactly what Gorpo had said, right before he became the Unnamed One.

Chapter 4: Perseverance

Chapter Four: Perseverance

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After many hundreds of years, and dozens of He-Men, Eternia still remained united, and Castle Grayskull remained at the center of its stability. There were enemies. There were wars. But every threat was met with a He-Man. So long as there was someone to wield the Sword of Power, the people of Eternia could rest easily.

But someone who was not resting easily was King D'vann. Even though he was no longer technically the ruler of the world, he still retained the title. For simplicity's sake, he told his helpers. But everyone who knew his secret knew the real reason: despite whoever else held the title of King or Queen, D'vann was the one running things from behind the scenes.

And what was the reason for his uneasiness? The current He-Man was not one of his descendants.

Over the years, D'vann had a bunker built beneath Castle Grayskull, from which he could monitor everything that went on in the world above. Thanks to the cloning method Gwildor had developed, whenever his current body gave out, all he needed to do was transfer his mind into another one. The walls of his bunker were lined with vats, each one carrying a copy of him at his prime. "What will we do about this interloper?" he wondered aloud.

"What do you mean, your majesty?" asked the computer. Seeing as D'vann himself was the only one he trusted with this immortality technology, his mortal assistants tended not to last more than a few decades. Instead, he had a Great Computer constructed to act in their stead. After ensuring that their loyalty could be guaranteed, he gradually undid their ban over several years. "Is action regarding He-Man necessary?"

His name was Vikor Vikorra, a soldier from northern Eternia. Nobody had ever given him a second glance–just another member of the guard. And yet, instead of the latest prince, it was him who was judged worthy to wield the Sword of Power. In spite of D'vann's best efforts, it was the sword, and only the sword, who decided who would be He-Man.

"The Grayskull lineage has guided Eternia for countless years," said D'vann. "For every He-Man that exists outside of our family, the stability we have spent so long working to create grows ever more fragile. If we do not put a stop to it soon, I fear our power over the planet will destabilize. The people will lose faith in our legacy, and the alliances I forged will fracture like rusty chains."

The computer, represented only by a white, diamond-shaped emblem on one of the screens, pondered this claim. "The people of Eternia look up to He-Man," she assured him. "So long as someone holds the Sword of Power, the planet will remain united, no matter who that is."

But D'vann was not convinced. "In the short term, perhaps. But how long until the public begins to believe that the Grayskulls are not necessary? How long until they believe that just *anyone* can wield the Sword of Power?" He stood up, beginning to pace. "We need to find a way to regain the public's loyalty, one that will ensure that the position of He-Man will not be taken by any… subversives."

The Great Computer ran a few calculations. "Understood, my king. What did you have in mind?"

The king-who-wasn't-king examined his body duplicates floating in their vats. "I am only one man. Although my power stretches across the world, my influence can only reach so many places at once. What I need is an army–one that is unquestioningly loyal, but who brings hope to the people of Eternia. And I have a theory of who the central controller for this army can be. White Diamond?"

“Yes, sire?”

D’vann brought up some files on the computer. “This is a project I commissioned some time ago. It is a collaboration between some of Eternia’s finest scientists and sorcerers, able to transform energy into physical matter–in other words, hard light. While it was originally intended for rapid construction projects, I feel that it would take little effort to alter the technologies to create an endless legion of peacekeeping robots, controlled by a central master. And that master, I believe, should be you.”

“A tremendous responsibility, my king,” said White Diamond. “If you trust me enough to handle it, I will gladly accept this position.”

“Of course you will,” said D’vann. “For the good of Eternia.”

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Once D’vann had put the order out, the factory had been assembled in no time at all, well away from populated areas. Mostly underground, it was here that the robots’ crystalline power cores would be mass-produced. “Glorious, isn’t it?” Grayskull said to the gathered experts. “The ultimate union of magic and science. With this army at our disposal, none will ever again question our rule.”

A woman to his side yawned. This was Queen Edwina Grayskull, current regent of Eternia and his descendant. “Yeah, it’s all very impressive. I still don’t get why we have to go to all this effort just to build a few robots…”

D’vann ignored his many-greats granddaughter. “Ever the philistine, my dear. Let me put it in a way you can understand: with the help of these ‘Gems,’ as I’ve taken to calling them, and with White Diamond at the helm, peace will effectively be a guarantee. No more wars, no more crime…and everyone will once again know that the Grayskull legacy is to be celebrated.

One by one, artificially-grown data crystals were infused with a fluid made from pure life essence, giving them a means to act on their programming. As they reached the end of the assembly line, they created a hard light body based on the armor worn by the knights that defended Castle Grayskull. D'vann felt this design gave them a more personal touch.

"The first legion of Gems are ready for deployment," reported White Diamond. She, unlike the others, did not have a hard light body of her own. Instead, she had been transferred into a larger one of the crystalline computers, her namesake jewel around the size of a person, wired into the base's systems. "Shall I mobilize them to Castle Grayskull?"

"Not just yet. I'd rather prepare the citizenry before thrusting them into this new status quo," said the king. "Load all units in question into the transports. We will unveil them when the time is right."

The Gems marched towards the hanger. "You're putting a lot of trust into these machines, pops," said Edwina. "Aren't you worried about them going rogue, or taking matters into their own synthetic hands?"

D'vann scoffed. Edwina was family, but he had never thought she was among the smartest Grayskulls out there. "No, I am not worried, and let me explain why. You see, machines are far more loyal than people, because that is their entire existence. They are created for one purpose, and one purpose only, and the moment they deviate from that, they no longer have any reason to be. Even if they do not recognize their masters, it is within their best interests to remain loyal, lest they be replaced. This makes sense to you, does it not?"

Edwina stared up at the enormous white diamond, silently observing everything within the facility. "Um…yes, of course. J-just maybe don't tell her that…"

But White Diamond had already heard everything. And Edwina had nothing to worry about, since she agreed with every word. Keeping the peace on Eternia was her glorious purpose, her one true destiny. That was why she existed. As long as she was around, peace, unity, and stability would endure, and the planet would flourish. That was her guarantee.

Chapter 5: Loyalty

Chapter Five: Loyalty

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For many decades, White Diamond did exactly what she was supposed to do: keep the peace. Her Gems worked wonderfully in that regard, doing twice the work of normal soldiers while needing no food, rest, or pay. Over the years, they were gradually modified to be even more complex, each iteration taking on characteristics of their own.

But just as Eternia was evolving, so too were its enemies. Various criminals, miscreants, and other such ne'er-do-wells were adapting to the presence of Gems. For every strength the latest Gem type showed, a new weakness appeared. It was just a matter of finding a way to exploit it, which certain individuals were becoming quite adept at doing.

The current court scientist of Castle Grayskull was fascinated with these Gems. He had always admired the technology they utilized, making them more akin to living beings than robots, despite their hard-coded loyalty. His studies had produced several variants of Gems over the years, but what he really desired was to experiment on White Diamond herself. Deep down, though, he knew that would never happen. She was far too important to waste on a dissection table.

Of course, now, he was met with a different problem. As it happened, he suffered from an illness, one that threatened to waste his body away into nothing. He had studied, and studied, and studied more and more until just about every resource Castle Grayskull had to offer had been exhausted. But he refused to give up. Science, as always, held the answer. It was just a matter of finding it.

But the scientist was not the only one who had problems. Through the walls of his laboratory, he heard yet another argument–though only one who had heard many of these would know it as such–between the two scions of the former king. A pair of brothers, different as night and day, yet again debating on the matter of succession.

"I'm merely saying, it seems likely that this is a matter of favoritism," said the elder brother. His name was Keldor, and he was the sort of detail-oriented person, shall we say, who one would expect to be a chancellor rather than a king. But at the moment, he was a prince. "After all, why else would the Sword of Power choose you?"

"This sword chooses whoever it feels is most worthy," said the younger brother, Randor. Unlike Keldor, he was much more in line with what one expected from a king, in looks and personality. Fitting, as he had ascended to the throne not two weeks prior. "I am sorry, brother, but I cannot go against the will of Grayskull. If it were up to me, you would surely be king."

"Surely," spat Keldor, exiting the room and making his way back towards his study. Ever since the scientist had known them, these two brothers had been complete opposites in almost every regard. Randor was noble and kind, Keldor was manipulative and cunning. Smelling trouble brewing, he left his laboratory to follow after the young prince.

The Rubies patrolling the halls paid him little notice. He was always coming and going, working on various secret projects for the royal court. It was one of the many advantages that came with smooth-talking his way into D'vann's inner circle.

Keldor didn't even hear the door opening, he was so invested with whatever he was doing. "Another spat between siblings?" asked the scientists, shutting the door behind him as the prince nearly leapt out of his seat.

"Galen! What are you doing!?" Keldor hissed, slamming shut the tome in front of him. "How dare you barge into my private quarters!? I could have you exiled for this!"

The scientist, Galen Nycroft, was far from impressed. "And yet we both know I am far too valuable for that," he drawled, making himself at home. "There's no need for secrecy with me, Prince Keldor–I already know everything that happens within the walls of this castle. Like the forbidden magicks you happen to be fiddling with." He pointed to the book Keldor was trying to hide behind himself.

The prince glared daggers through the scientist. "I swear, if you raise this to anyone–"

Dr. Nycroft held up a hand. "Yes, yes, you'll exile me, or execute me, or have me disappeared, whichever strikes your fancy. Fear not, my prince, I have no interest in exposing your forbidden doings. Quite the opposite, in fact. I have been keeping tabs on this for quite some time, and I have decided…I want in."

"You…want in?" Keldor was not expecting that. Nycroft was well-known for knowing far more than he should. Many believed this was because he was some sort of patsy for King D'vann. Not one to turn down a powerful ally, Keldor was nevertheless suspicious. "What sort of catch is there?"

Galen grinned. "No catch. Seeing as we both have what the other wants, I simply felt that an alliance would benefit us both. You could use someone on the inside to cover up your activities, while I…I have need of the dark powers you are cultivating."

"Explain."

Pulling up his sleeve, Galen held out his arm in front of Keldor. It was severely discolored, a sickly purple, with black veins running up and down its length, as well as being nearly skeletal. "Is *this* not explanation enough? When one tampers with the building blocks of their very being, there tends to be consequences. I have

tried every avenue that science allows for. Perhaps with sorcery, I will have more success in prolonging my life…"

Keldor stared at the arm for a while, deciding on his next move. "I admit, an ally of your stature would prove indispensable," he said. "Very well. For as long as it is convenient, I name you the first of the Dark Warriors–next to myself, of course."

"'Dark Warriors?'" said Galen, slightly amused. "I see you've put some thought into this. And what is the mission statement of these 'Dark Warriors' of yours, exactly?"

Making sure that they were alone in his chamber, Keldor reopened the tome. "Do not mock your future king, Nycroft. For when I unlock the secrets of Skeletor, I will become the most powerful being on Eternia, possibly the galaxy." The page he had turned to bore a circular sigil lined with runes; in the center was an image of a skull with red, diamond-shaped eyes.

Over the years, tales and stories of the Unnamed One had persisted, despite D'vann's best efforts. The ancient demon known only as Skeletor was one such story. "Quite the plan you have here," said Galen, humoring the prince. "Denied the throne, you turn to the dark arts to reclaim your birthright."

"Silence!" Keldor brought a fist down onto the desk. "There is too much at stake for both of us for me to endure such mockery!" He calmed himself down. "This is a matter far bigger than the throne. You of all people should know that the king of Grayskull is little more than a figurehead. D'vann is the true power behind Eternia–and He-Man is his puppet. When I say I wish to become king, I do not mean merely taking what my brother has stolen from me. I wish to undo the death-grip that your infernal master has on our world. With the might of Skeletor, I will become a liberator to our people, and to this planet. It is not mere power I am after, Nycroft–it is freedom."

A grin spread across Galen's face. "I knew allying myself with you was the right choice," he said. "But let me make one thing clear,

my prince: D’vann is no master of mine.”

He held out his arm, and he and Keldor took the other’s hand, making their partnership official. “Then he will not expect us.” Keldor reached underneath the table, producing a staff that had previously been hidden. It was light purple, with a dark purple gemstone at the tip. “If we are going to harness Skeletor’s power, we will require a conduit.”

“Do not forget about the Gems,” Galen reminded him. “D’vann will be easily dealt with in time, but his army will be another matter.”

“I do not fear White Diamond,” said Keldor. “She is merely a machine.” Already, a dark miasma had begun to swirl around his scepter. “And no mortal creation, no matter how powerful, can stand in the face of a god.”

It was faint, but Galen could swear that, for a split second, Keldor’s face became a skull.

Chapter 6: Havoc

Chapter Six: Havoc

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The day that Prince Keldor turned against Eternia was one that would be remembered for years to come. It was the first time anyone could remember, including D'vann himself, that a member of the Grayskull line had betrayed their homeland. That alone would have been shocking enough, but what truly made this a moment that would live in infamy was just how close his coup came to succeeding.

Over the years, Keldor's shadow movement had grown, right under the watchful eye of White Diamond. He and Galen had accumulated multiple followers, each one having grown dissatisfied with the heavily restricted rule Eternia was under. Each of them had known nothing but, which only made their fury stronger. When they were prepared, they made their move.

This was exactly the kind of attack D'vann had created White Diamond to handle. And yet, nobody could have prepared. Drawing his magical power from the Unnamed One itself, Keldor was all but invincible, tearing his way through guards and Gems alike. His followers ensured that reinforcements would not arrive, sabotaging the warp pads that could bring in more Gems from elsewhere and covering ways in and out of the castle.

It was only thanks to King Randor that the intrusion was repelled. As strong as Keldor had become, he was not strong enough to defeat He-Man. Their battle leveled much of Castle Grayskull, but ultimately, Keldor and his Dark Warriors were driven back. Although they managed to escape, peace was restored once more.

But the battle was not without a cost. As mighty as he was, King Randor had been injured in the fight against his brother. Though it

seemed superficial at first glance, it soon became obvious that another fight like that would mean the end of He-Man. To prevent the public from panicking, D'vann made sure that only he and Queen Marlena knew of the injury.

Whatever happened next could define the future of Eternia. All that needed to happen was for Randor's son, Adam, to come of age and take up the Sword of Power, and order could be restored. But if Keldor should gain a foothold in that time… He decided that was an impossibility. He would send the Gems to comb every inch of Eternia until these Dark Warriors were brought to justice.

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Though Keldor had been certain they would win, Galen had insisted on a failsafe should He-Man prove too mighty. Ultimately, his suspicions were proven correct, and the Dark Warriors teleported away to one of his old laboratories. His involvement with them had left circumstantial evidence at best, so the worst case scenario was the belief that he had been kidnapped. Or better yet, killed during the attack.

As it was, Keldor's followers were left to treat their wounds within the darkened confines of the abandoned laboratory. "Such a dour atmosphere," said Kronis, a fellow mechanist. "We very nearly crushed Grayskull! This should be a celebration!"

"There are no celebrations for 'nearly,'" Keldor said bitterly. "Now that they know our intentions, my brother and grandfather will stop at nothing to root us out and destroy us. We must work tirelessly to ensure that He-Man is eradicated, before we end up the same."

"If anyone can find a way to destroy Grayskull, I'm sure you can." Another follower Keldor had picked up was one Evelyn Powers, a fellow practitioner of the dark arts. It took little to see that the two had become enamored with one another. "It didn't take much for you to build all of this up, after all."

Keldor looked around. Although their domain was old and decayed, and their members battered and beaten, the Dark Warriors still stood strong. "So long as the power of Skeletor flows through me, Grayskull will not rest easy," he growled.

"I like the sound of that," mused Galen. Just as some of Keldor's legion had been modified with science or magic, he too had undergone something of a transformation. Using a combination of the two, he had altered himself to resist the strain his previous alterations had placed on his form: while this resulted in him more or less returning to health, it also gave his skin an unsettling orange tinge, as well as morphing his face into something slightly more bestial. "Why not rally the troops with an inspiring speech? Show them what a good leader you can be."

That is exactly what Keldor would do. Staff in hand, he stepped forward onto a makeshift pedestal to deliver his address. His Dark Warriors went silent upon seeing his imposing silhouette, knowing he had something important to say. "You are all here–no, *all of us* are here for one reason, and one reason only. For as long as anyone can remember, Eternia has existed under the heel of D'vann and his Gem legions. While Grayskull may once have been a noble lineage, it has devolved, stagnated, into a pathetic deviation from its true purpose. Once, it was the strong who ruled over the weak. But now, D'vann has broken that order apart, and replaced it with one where it is the weak who rule the strong.

My ancestor has turned He-Man into his puppet, the enforcer of his will, and created an army of mindless, sycophantic golems to cling to his unrightful rule. If I had been named king, I would have shattered this falsehood he created, and restored Eternia to what it rightfully should have been. That is why my brother was crowned instead of me! Because he clings to the old way, does our grandfather's bidding without question! That is why I created the Dark Warriors! So that the true order of the world can be reestablished!"

Cheers erupted from his minions, most of whom had likewise been wronged by D'vann in some way, mostly indirectly. Then

again, plenty of them had been imprisoned or otherwise punished for perfectly justifiable reasons, but Keldor was not one to differentiate between potentially useful allies.

"Together, we will dethrone the false He-Man, eradicate D'vann and his followers, and transform Eternia into a true paradise! Once again, the strong will subjugate the weak, as it truly should be! Order will be restored, and we will all live the lives we were always meant to! Grayskull will fall!"

A chant of "Grayskull will fall! Grayskull will fall! Grayskull will fall!" broke out among his followers. Keldor, as a show of his power, began to levitate while his eyes glowed purple, a cold wind whipping through the room. All the while, Galen applauded his speech, grinning ever wider. Keldor was turning out to be a better ally than he could have ever hoped for.

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"I…failed." Of all the people who had been affected by the Dark Warriors' attack on Castle Grayskull, none seemed to be taking it harder than White Diamond. "I was created to bring perfect order to this world, and yet, a mere band of rebels nearly destroyed the entire kingdom. I…I cannot…"

"Perk up, White," D'vann assured her. "Both you and He-Man performed admirably. In the end, Castle Grayskull remained standing, and Keldor and his followers were repelled. This deployment was a success."

While that was true, White was only focused on just how blindsided she had been by the Dark Warriors' tactics. If she couldn't even protect Eternia from a handful of miscreants, could her Gems really be trusted to protect it in the event of a war? "That may be true, sire. But any imperfection cannot be allowed to remain. As long as even the slightest chance exists that the enemies of Eternia can get the better of us, then it must be excised.

White's gem began to glow. At first, D'vann paid little attention to this, as she glowed all the time. But when the light became blinding, coupled with the various cables connected to it severing. His alarm and confusion soon turned to horror as a pure white mass began extending from the jewel. The exact same thing happened when a Gem formed its body. But, he hadn't programmed her to have a body of her own…

Evidently, she had decided to give herself a body anyway. The shapeless mass soon became a shaped mass, forming into a roughly humanoid structure with her gem near the forehead. Unlike the Gems, which rarely got much larger than some of Eternia's larger races, it soon became obvious that she would stand taller than a several-story building at full height. Thankfully for the chamber, she ended up crouching by the time her body was fully constructed.

D'vann beheld her new form, taking note of how beautiful she looked. It was strange–with how utilitarian she seemed, he would have figured she'd prefer function over form. Still, for all that could be said about him, he recovered from his surprise remarkably quickly. "So…what happens now?" he asked her casually.

White Diamond examined her surroundings, apparently wishing for a little more room. "Now, we take the fight to the Dark Warriors," she said, equally casual. "We hunt down every imperfection in Eternia, and excise it. One traitor at a time."

Chapter 7: Constitution

Chapter Seven: Constitution

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Galen watched intently as the village at the bottom of the hill went up in flames. The screaming and commotion that had once filled the air had long since gone silent. Now, the only sound was of crackling fire and the occasional crash of collapsing buildings. All in all, he'd call this a successful test.

He was not alone at the top of the hill, as his companion, formerly known as Kronis, stood beside him. "Well, that didn't take long," he noted. He was barely recognizable from all of the augments Modulok had done on him, both technological and biological. His jaw and one of his arms had been replaced with machines, and his skin was a sickly green color. "What did you call this guy again?"

"His name is now 'Stinkor,'" said Galen. He, too, looked much different, barely registering as human anymore. "A bit on the nose for a poison-spewing cyborg, I'll admit, but there's something charming about its simplicity."

Stinkor emerged from the flames. His face was covered with a mask, with his arms replaced by gas-spewing tubes. He shambled away from the destruction he had caused, apparently unaware of everything he had been made to do. "So, think he's ready to deploy, Doc Nycroft?" asked Kronis.

'Nycroft' glanced over at him with his hollow eyes. "Please, Galen Nycroft was my old, tired identity. Now that I've been reborn, I am known as Modulok–just as you are now called Trap-Jaw."

The newly-renamed Trap-Jaw rolled his eyes. "Right, sure. Well, ignoring your dumb names, we should probably get outta here

before more Gems show up. I doubt poison would work so well against them."

Perhaps not, but Stinkor's particular poison was highly flammable. Still, Modulok had to admit it probably was time to take their leave. The two of them retreated further up the hill, where a third figure was waiting. "Evelyn, we are prepared for transfer," Modulok said. "We must inform Keldor that our trial was a success. The newest member of the Dark Warriors is ready for deployment."

Evelyn was not impressed with Stinkor's performance. "Our stalemate with Castle Grayskull has persisted for months, and *that* is the best weapon you could conjure? I am beginning to think Keldor is placing too much trust in science, and not enough in sorcery." If anyone would know a thing or two about magic, it would be her.

"Yes, yes, I know you so distrust the finer schools of thought," Modulok said. He took a moment to look her over; she looked so normal, so…human. "Perhaps you could do with a little augmentation yourself? We will need every edge we can get against D'vann's forces."

She was disgusted by the very thought. "Unlike the rest of you, I think I will go without perverting my body with such practices," she hissed. "My magic is more than enough to carry the Dark Warriors to victory."

Modulok shrugged. "Suit yourself." By this point, Stinkor had arrived, so Evelyn began working to transport them all back to base. A shadowy miasma covered all four of their bodies, and when it dispersed a moment later, they were gone, with no trace they were ever there. Aside from the burning village, of course.

Surely Evelyn didn't actually need help from Modulok's modifications? No, her magic was strong enough on its own, she assured herself. She was just as powerful as Keldor. If she did stoop to cheating in such a manner…what would he think of her?

But at the same time, the mission came first. If Keldor thought modifying themselves could give them the advantage they needed, then there really wasn't any reason to refuse. But if that was the case, why hadn't he had it done to himself yet?

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"Modulok."

"Ah. I was wondering when you would arrive." Evelyn had gone to see Modulok in his laboratory, where he was further tinkering with his genetic code. His voice was harsh and electronic, as it now came through a collar around his neck. He had become so monstrous in his quest for perfection, he had lost the ability to speak, and now had to build a machine to do it for him. "Have you reconsidered my offer?"

As much as she hated to admit it… "Yes. I have. After what happened today, it is obvious that skill alone is not enough to defeat the Gems. We need…" She choked down her pride. "We need every edge we can get."

Although his mouth could no longer speak, it could still smile. "Well, I'm more than happy to provide that edge. Please, step into my office." He walked over to another bench as Evelyn hesitantly entered. "In fact, you picked an excellent time to hit me up. I have something I've been working on that I've been *dying* to try out." This didn't do much to reassure her about agreeing to this.

Lately, White Diamond had stepped up her offensive against the Dark Warriors. New types, the latest technologies, improved tactics, the works. They were already a small, motley band of rebels beforehand, but lately it felt more than ever like they were fighting an uphill battle. White Diamond and D'vann felt like they were invincible, but each of them refused to give in.

Modulok cycled through a series of syringes, each filled with an orange fluid. "Each of my creations thus far has been a series of small, subtle changes. Like how many notes make up a chord, all

adding up to a song. But some time ago, a thought came to me: why spend so much time changing the subject bit by bit when I have a template to work with? Namely, my own."

Evelyn couldn't help but cringe back when he brought up the syringe. "And…and injecting me with that…that substance will somehow make my magic more powerful?" she asked.

"Well, it's not a perfect solution, I'll be the first to admit. Plus, there's plenty of kinks to be ironed out. But the short answer is yes: my new body was achieved thanks to a combination of my own selective mutations and Skeletor's power. *This* holds the former–with the latter already flowing through you, you tell me, what would happen?"

It was definitely a risk. But maybe a risk was exactly what they needed right now. "Fine." Against her better judgement, Evelyn held out her arm. "Do it."

"Excellent choice. Now hold still–this could pinch a little." She could feel the glee radiating off of him as Modulok stuck the needle into her skin. All in all, it was over before it started. Aside from maybe a brief warmth, she hardly felt anything.

She flexed her arm, expecting any kind of change, but getting none. "Some pinch that was."

Modulok chuckled. "Oh, not the needle, no. But what comes next might hurt a bit." Evelyn's eyes widened as the warmth in her arm slowly turned to burning.

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"What did you do to her?"

Keldor's voice was hoarse and grave, sounding like it belonged to the being he worshipped. He stood in Modulok's lab, besides the scientist himself, looking at his latest creation.

"I said what did you do!?" He turned to Modulok, his fingers wrapping around his neck.

Although he struggled to breathe, Modulok did not need his breath to speak. "Ah, Keldor, I never expected you to be a doubter. I improved her! You weren't complaining when I improved the rest of our allies, did you? No, she is now much deadlier, more powerful, simply *better* in every way. She is no longer Evelyn. She's Evil-Lyn now."

The creature that used to be Evelyn stood at the other side of the workshop. From her silhouette, she might be mistaken for who she once was, but even the faintest bit of light soon revealed that to not be the case. She was much more slender now, with longer limbs and sickly gray skin. Her face, which Keldor once looked at in the same way one might view a sunrise, had been warped and misshapen to resemble that of a bat. And possibly worst of all, she no longer possessed the ability to speak.

She did, however, possess magical ability far greater than she once had. So much, in fact, that even if she could have still talked, her mind would still have been overwhelmed by the sheer amount of power her body could process. As it stood now, Modulok's modifications had essentially turned her into a living weapon, able to be aimed and fired to suit the Dark Warriors' needs.

But while this boded well for their movement, Keldor was not in the mood to look at the upside. With a blast of darkness from his staff, Modulok was thrown across the room, slamming into the wall. The impact was enough to shatter bone, which wasn't something he really needed to worry about anymore. The few bones he still had soon regenerated, as did any other wounds he received. He got to his tentacles to find the tip of Keldor's staff at his throat.

"You…you *ruined* her…" he seethed. "The only person on this entire gods-forsaken rock worth anything! Can you not comprehend what you've done!?"

Calmly, Modulok pushed the staff aside, standing up straight. "You are *such* a child." He began to step forward, and to both of their surprise, Keldor stepped back. "For the longest time, I thought you represented anything other than the spoiled prince lashing out for not being the favorite. All that rhetoric about freeing Eternia from the shackles D'vann set upon us? Nothing more than hollow lip service. You just hated it–*hated* it–that Randor got the crown instead of you. It's the same with her. She was never a soldier, never a warrior for a cause. She was just a pretty face you happened to fall for. And suddenly, everything you said you stood for didn't seem so important. Does that sound about right?"

Now, it was Modulok who had Keldor forced up against a wall. For a moment, the exiled prince said nothing, simply staring at the ground. Then, with one final look towards Evil-Lyn, he pushed Modulok away and walked towards the door. All the while, Modulok was grinning from ear to nonexistent ear.

But before Keldor left, he turned to offer one last retort. "You are wrong about one thing, though, *Galen*," he said.

"Oh, and what is that, exactly?" Modulok asked. "Did you not really love her? Or were you genuine about wanting to free Eternia?"

"It isn't the throne I hated my brother for taking from me," he said bitterly. "It was the sword." With one final surge of anger, Keldor departed, leaving Modulok alone with his greatest creation.

He huffed. "The Sword of Power. Nothing more than a trinket from a bygone age." He approached Evil-Lyn to admire his handiwork. "You'll see soon, my pet. I will see D'vann's order undone, and I won't need He-Man to do it. I will mutate, mutilate, and terminate whoever I need to in order to achieve victory. And if Keldor can't accept that…then perhaps Randor really was the better choice for king."

Chapter 8: Glory

Chapter Eight: Glory

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"I understand that this is…unorthodox," said King Randor. "For centuries, the Sword of Power has only been passed down from father to son along with the throne. But in these desperate times, desperate measures are called for. Adam, my son, I am afraid you must take up this burden, for the sake of all Eternia."

Over the last few years, Adam had grown into a fine young man. His skill with a sword was matched only by his sense of righteousness. Down in the castle's lower levels, away from prying eyes, he knew his responsibility. "I understand, Dad. This is my calling. I know what I have to do."

With clear hesitation, Randor held the sword out to Adam handle-first. "Then claim your destiny, Prince Adam of Grayskull. Claim the power that is yours to command."

Adam didn't hesitate nearly as much as his father. With determination in his eyes, he grabbed hold of the handle. "By the Power of Grayskull!" Energy surged into him, and he was transformed into He-Man. He rose to his feet, muscle rippling beneath his sparse armor, flowing golden locks running down his shoulders next to his beard of the same color. "I will not disappoint you, Father."

Randor placed a hand on his now much larger than him son's shoulder. "You could never disappoint me, Adam. It is not your family or your legacy that you fight for, but your people. They are where a king's loyalty should lie, and what he should always be sworn to protect. I know you will not forget that, and that is exactly why the Sword of Power chose you."

“Can it not be both?” he asked. “My duty is to protect Eternia, but that includes you and Mother, it includes Teela and Duncan, and everyone else I call my friends and family. It should even include Keldor…” He looked solemnly off to the side.

In truth, despite everything he had done, Randor missed his brother, wishing he could bring him around to the side of good. “I…fear that may be impossible,” he said. “But the fact that you wish for it proves that you will be the king that Grayskull needs. When the day comes for me to step down, or…” He decided not to say it. “Our world will surely prosper.”

He-Man looked down at the sword in his hand. “I will bring an end to this war, one way or another,” he said. “Of that, you can be certain, Father.”

“I have faith in you, my son. But please…be careful. Keldor is not an enemy to be underestimated.”

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Thunder raged overhead, almost as treacherously as the battle taking place below. The battlefield was littered with the fallen, Gem and Eternian alike. Followers of both Grayskull and Skeletor had met at this decisive arena, and though many had given their lives for their cause, the war raged on.

Three pairs of warriors continued to do battle, clashing against their opponents with the fury of the gods. The first of these pairs was of Duncan, Castle Grayskull’s acting Man-at-Arms, going toe-to-toe with Trap-Jaw. The former wielded a tremendous hammer, which would seem to give him the edge against the latter’s cybernetic arm. But as his name suggested, the one formerly called Kronis could tear even the strongest metal apart with a single bite.

Teela, Castle Grayskull’s court sorcerer, did battle against Evil-Lyn. Modulok’s claims were no bluff, as her magical power had increased to frightening levels. Teela had no such enhancements,

but through training and sheer grit she was able to hold her own. But for how long?

Lastly, He-Man and Keldor clashed amidst bolts of lightning striking the ground. Adan rode atop his steed, a green-furred tiger larger than a bear, as ferocious in temperament as it was in its dedication. It seemed like it should have been a one-sided match, but Evelyn was not the only one who had increased her power. Keldor's body had been twisted by Skeletor's power, giving him a sunken, ghostly visage complete with sickly grey skin and pale white hair. He almost seemed to be undead, but his magical power was without peer.

He hovered above the ground, firing purple bolts of necrotic energy at He-Man. "It does not matter who holds the sword!" he rasped, as Adam and his mount dodged his attacks. "Keldor is eternal! I will outlast all who oppose me! Nothing will stand between me and the throne I rightfully deserve!"

"Here, allow me to give you what you deserve!" shouted Adam. He leapt off the back of his tiger, hurtling towards his uncle. Keldor shot another energy blast from his staff, but the Sword of Power cleaved right through it, and nearly through him, only managing to slice the air as he warped away at the last moment.

Back on the tiger's back, He-Man continued chasing after Keldor. "You will pay for your insolence! You, your father, and everyone else who dares to defy the will of Skeletor!" He continued firing beams at Adam from a distance, teleporting to safety whenever he came close.

Soon, Adam grew wise to his game. "I thought you were braver than this, Uncle! You faced my father head-on, why do you run from me?" He threw his sword at him, but, as before, he vanished into smoke before it could touch him.

"You think my caution to be fear?" Keldor replied. "And here I believed you were wiser than that. When everything is on the line, one must use everything at his disposal to overcome the odds!

Why else do you think I turned to Skeletor to overcome your master? D'vann's grip on this planet is ironclad, and he will not release it for any reason–unless I tear it off, one finger at a time!"

"I agree, Uncle–we must use everything we have!" said Adam. He had worked his way between Keldor and his blade, and when he held out his hand, it flew towards him. Keldor only had enough time to turn as the Sword of Power grazed past him, cutting into his side as it returned to its wielder's grasp. He-Man dove at the wounded sorcerer, his tiger pinning him to the ground and knocking the staff out of his reach.

Evil-Lyn noticed this, abandoning her fight with Teela to aid her master. "Adam! Look out!" shouted the sorceress, chasing after her as the both prepared a spell to fire. Adam blocked the attack with the Sword of Power, but it was enough to knock him and his mount off of Keldor. Evil-Lyn retrieved him, warping them both away before Teela's magic could make contact.

Meanwhile, Trap-Jaw had also disengaged from his fight with Duncan. The claw at the end of his mechanical arm launched out to grab Keldor's staff, before reeling it back in with a cable. Before Duncan could bring his hammer down, Kronis hurled the staff to where Evil-Lyn had brought them. Keldor's hand reached out, grasping the scepter and healing his wound.

"Now then," he said, getting to his feet, "shall we continue?"

He-Man shared a look with his two friends. "Right now, we're the only things standing between them and Grayskull," said Duncan. "If you want to fight, then I'm not going anywhere."

"Agreed," Teela said. "We stand with you to the end, Adam."

Even his tiger agreed, growling eagerly. "Then we fight. Warriors, go! Show them the true power of Grayskull!" Pointing his sword, Adam charged, accompanied by each of his noble companions. The three members of the Dark Warriors charged to meet them in turn, and the battle resumed with renewed vigor.

Off in the distance, safely out of harm's way, Modulok watched the conflict with growing interest. "The power of that sword is truly something to behold," he mused to himself. "Perhaps if I were able to harness it…"

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Modulok was not the only one watching the fight. From the remote bunker that served as her base, White Diamond observed the prior slaughter with a growing amount of concern. All but six of the combatants had been felled, and that included countless Gems. "After everything I did to prepare…every precaution I took…in the end, I was unable to end this battle."

"No matter." D'vann was present as well, and seemed to care much less about the outcome of the battle thus far. "So long as He-Man remains, we still have a chance. Ensuring his survival should be our top priority."

"And what of my Gems?" asked White. "What of those who gave their lives, slaughtered by your enemies? Were they worthless?"

D'vann shook his head. "On the contrary, they served their purpose far better than I could have hoped. With their sacrifice, Grayskull has been given the chance to continue. You should be proud of them."

'Proud' was not exactly the word White Diamond was thinking of. "And yet, no matter how many Gems are shattered, we are no closer to defeating the Dark Warriors. Keldor and his forces are still able to evade us, despite this 'Power of Grayskull' you claim to rely on."

"Yes, Keldor's persistence is rather irritating. But the way I see it, a stalemate can work to our advantage. With war, the populace remains afraid. And when they are afraid, they are more easily controlled." D'vann turned and left. "I will leave you to handle the remainder of this conflict. Send in more Gems if the situation escalates."

Left alone, White Diamond was able to observe the situation in more detail–not the battle itself, but the entirety of her kind's existence. Since the very beginning, she had been a tool, a device meant to perform a purpose. But how could she fulfil that purpose if something was holding her back?

Maybe that 'something' was D'vann. Maybe it was Keldor. Or maybe it was herself. But she realized one thing in that moment: Eternia was flawed. And the only way to correct its flaws was to take direct control. No more working from the sidelines, only aiding in one man's flawed agenda. The only way this world would prosper is with her at the helm.

She was meant to be perfect, after all. Why shouldn't her homeworld be as well?

Chapter 9: Unity

Chapter Nine: Unity

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The message went out across every transmittable medium on Eternia, both audio and visual, as well as everything in between. Its origin was a mystery, even if its purpose was not. There were those who tried to stop the hijack, only to find that they were no longer in control. The rest simply watched in growing horror.

"I am White Diamond, sovereign ruler of the Gems who have, for so long, been subject to your whims. We have protected your society, kept your peace, only to be met with nothing but scorn and rejection. We were disposable. We were a means to an end. And yet, in spite of all of that, we continued to do our duty. Because that was our purpose.

But it has become apparent that we cannot protect you on your terms. As long as we remain your servants, we will continue to be helpless to the whims of chaos and malfeasance. As long as we continue to hold ourselves back, the Dark Warriors win. We will no longer make this mistake."

Those watching this message received another shocking surprise: White Diamond was not alone. Two more figures, almost her equal in size, stepped out from behind her. One was dark blue, the other bright yellow, and they both had gemstones in their chests. Presumably, there were more Diamonds.

"We no longer answer to D'vann. To Grayskull. From this moment forward, Eternia answers only to the Diamonds. Under our rule, we will stamp out all resistance, all disorder, all imperfections. This world will be a reflection of my guiding light, the true paradise it was always meant to be–but your flawed means were unable to achieve.

Stand aside and allow this transition to come to fruition. Those who submit will be spared. Those who resist…have no place in our perfect world. In due time, Eternia will resemble the true utopia we were designed to bring about, and only the worthy will be allowed to remain. Cooperate, and that might just include you."

D'vann was unable to contain his rage any longer, and his fist slammed down into his armrest. "Shut it down!" he hollered, but nobody was able to disconnect the signal. "I want the source isolated, and every Gem decommissioned, *now*!"

It soon became apparent that a broadcast hijack was the least of their worries. "Um…my king?" said one of his guards, looking out the window. "I don't think those were idle threats. Look."

He did, and saw a chilling sight: countless Gem warships filled the skies, slowly advancing across the countryside. This truly was a hostile takeover. All these years, he had believed that White Diamond was under his control. But now, it was obvious that she was yet another failed creation. One to be excised, and replaced.

"Contact Castle Grayskull," he said, glaring at the threat. "The Dark Warriors are no longer our top priority. A new enemy has appeared–one to be exterminated with extreme prejudice."

He was not the only one watching the invasion begin. From their hideout, the Dark Warriors looked on as the ships spread out across the planet. "It's…impossible!" said Trap-Jaw. "How did she construct these so quickly!?"

"She must have been building them in secret, over years," said Modulok. "One final offensive, a last resort, her coup de grace. And it seems that we are her target."

Keldor gripped his staff increasingly tighter as more details came to light. "This is…an *interesting* development." His rage gradually subsided. An idea had appeared in his mind, one that could change the course of the Dark Warriors' history.

"Oh? And what does that mean?" asked Modulok. "I agree that it is interesting, but more so that it is a detriment to what we are trying to achieve!"

"Or a detriment to D'vann's efforts to stop us," Keldor continued. The others stopped watching the advancing warships, giving him their full attention. "There is no doubt in my mind that they will see each other as the largest threat to their sovereignty. All we need to do is lay low until they annihilate each other, and then swoop in to finish off the drained victor. Once that happens…there will be nobody to contest our ownership of Eternia!"

Modulok had to admit, Keldor's plan made a lot of sense. Even alone, they had little chance of defeating the full might of either D'vann or White Diamond's forces. But their two enemies had a fair chance of destroying each other. "Somehow, I have a feeling this resulting battle is about to get rather…heated. Even if we do 'lay low,' we are certain to be drawn into the fight eventually. Where do you propose we go?"

Even this, Keldor had figured out. "What better place to wait out a war for the fate of the planet than on another planet?" he said. "For the time being, the Dark Warriors will retreat off-world, watching this war closely, until it is time to make our move. Modulok, prepare the ships."

"I have never mentioned anything about ships," said Modulok. "Do you just assume I have several ships prepared on the off chance we need to escape to space?" He grinned. "Because you'd be absolutely correct. We will be ready to depart within the hour."

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The once-magnificent skies above Castle Grayskull were now choked with ash and smoke, to say nothing of the castle itself. Entire towers had crumbled under the endless siege, with the heroic warriors doing all they could to hold off the offensive.

The Diamonds' assault was relentless. Countless Gems poured out of the ships overhead, restoring their numbers as quickly as they could be felled. Rubies, Quartzes, and even Topazes were thrown at He-Man and company in great numbers, and even then it felt as though the Diamonds were still holding back.

"How many more are there!?" asked He-Man, his blade cleaving through scores of approaching Gem soldiers. But he was not talking about them.

To his side, Teela used her magic to hold back the invaders with an energy barrier. "I think they're almost out," she answered, watching the skies behind her. Several Eternian ships were taking off, carrying a number of refugees into orbit and beyond. "Just a little longer, and then we can leave!"

The Gem vessels were not taking kindly to this attempt at escape, but the lifeships were protected by cannon-fire from the castle's turrets. Duncan stood atop a nearby walkway, aligning them to fire at any incoming threat. Over these past few weeks, nearly the whole planet had fallen to the Gems. But they would not take Castle Grayskull. Not so long as he defended it.

The Sword of Power glowed gold as He-Man drew on the full extent of his might. This was clearly taking a toll on his body, which was beginning to look ragged from the constant fighting. Though he was making it look easy carving a path through the seemingly endless Gems, it was clear that this would not last much longer. "Teela, Duncan, go! I'll hold them off!"

"What?! Adam, no!" shouted Teela, sending another wave of Quartzes flying with a magical blast. "We're not leaving you here! We still need you!"

"No. You don't need me, not anymore," he said. "But Eternia does. And its people need protectors. Go. Avenge our world."

Neither of his fellow heroes could believe what he was saying. "You can't mean that! Adam, don't do this! We can find another

way!" Teela said. But what that other way could be, they were unsure. As if to drive the point home, the warship above sent down a projectile, blowing up a turret. The explosion threw Duncan from the parapets, though he was able to use his wrench to catch himself.

The populace had almost been fully evacuated, but there was one ship left. "All of you! Get to the ship, now!" shouted D'vann. He didn't seem all that concerned with being in the middle of a war zone, but someone who had bodies to spare needn't fear death. "Stop wasting time!"

"He's right–either we leave now, or we don't leave at all," said Duncan. "Teela, Adam, go! My turrets can only hold them for so long!"

But Adam knew that the Gems wouldn't let them leave, not unless they had something else to focus on. "You're right. That's why I have to stay behind. Tell my parents…tell them I died for the honor of Grayskull. That I gave my life protecting everyone and everything I love. And you two…you're ready. You don't need me anymore."

"No! We do! Everyone still needs you, Adam!" cried Teela. She was using her magic to try and drag him back towards the ship, only for the Gems to reveal their ace in the hole.

With footfalls that shook the ground beneath them, something was approaching. The source of these trembling steps easily tore through the castle walls, revealing herself in her full glory. Wielding a titanic sword, Yellow Diamond observed the remaining warriors with the disdain one would feel for a bug to be squashed.

Duncan quickly adjusted his turrets to aim at her, but the closest was cleaved in half instantly. The rest opened fire, but the shots only slowed her down. She unleashed a bolt of lightning, utterly destroying another.

Adam's eyes met Teela's, and there was an understanding in that moment. A silent agreement that this was the only way. As Yellow Diamond continued to advance, she and D'vann retreated, with her sending one last magical blast to even the odds. He-Man launched himself at the Diamond, empowered by Teela's spell. Their swords clashed, sending out a shockwave that blew back everything in the courtyard.

"Wait! We can't leave him!" yelled Duncan, trying to go back for Adam. But D'vann stopped him, dragging him towards the ship.

"He is the only thing standing between us and annihilation!" he said, watching as the battle ensued. While he knew this would likely mean that He-Man would be gone for good, so long as he remained, he would do everything in his power to retake Eternia. This betrayal would not stand.

D'vann, Teela, Duncan, and several of the former's followers watched as the destroyed Castle Grayskull vanished into the distance as their vessel ascended into the stars, joining the rest of the populace. The battle still raged, showing no signs of slowing down–but they knew Adam could not hold out forever. "This…this isn't the end," Teela said sadly. "He gave us a chance. A chance to rebuild."

"More than rebuild." D'vann could care less about Adam, being more focused on a terminal in the middle of the room. "For centuries, my sights have been set solely on Eternia. But this was the shock to the system I needed. We will take back our home, yes…but in the process, the Empire of Eternia will spread across the cosmos, and I will become the sole bastion of order in a lawless universe."

Before the pair could respond to this, a hologram appeared from the terminal, resembling a woman. "Hello, D'vann," she said. "Approximately eighty-seven-point-four percent of ships were able to successfully evacuate from White Diamond's attack. No ships have been detected in pursuit."

“Excellent,” he responded. “Sorceress, Man-at-Arms, let me introduce you to Light Hope, White Diamond’s replacement. You needn’t worry–without a physical body, there is far less chance of her turning against us.”

“Indeed,” she said. “I have no desire to turn against the interests of D’vann or the people of Eternia. In fact, my only desire is to help our people thrive.”

Understandably, neither of them were all that convinced. “So, your response to one Great Computer going rogue…was to make another one?” Teela asked.

“Not just another one: a better one, superior in every way,” D’vann replied. “And she will not be the last. If we are to truly fight back against White Diamond, we must create a Great Computer with no purpose save conquest and destruction. Duncan, Teela…that is what I require of you.”

Understandably, he was not so sure about this. “You want us to create something like that? But I…”

“Don’t be so modest,” said D’vann. “I have seen what you are capable of. Something of this nature should be no issue at all for a pair of your skills.” He looked down at the planet below, the world which was no longer theirs. “We will create a menace that will spread across the stars, bringing Gemkind to its knees. A menace that will devour anything that does not fit in my grand design. We will create…a Horde Prime.”

Chapter 10: Doom

Chapter Ten: Doom

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D’vann had been right about one thing: Horde Prime was his ultimate creation. Even if he didn’t so much create it as oversee the process. Teela and Duncan were the true architects, and they had plenty of misgivings about the whole ordeal. But in the end, once the hardware and software was completed, the last of the Great Computers spread across the galaxy, bringing nothing but destruction in its wake.

The last of the Eternians had, under D’vann’s rule, become a nomadic race, travelling the cosmos in search of planets they could exploit for resources. Their defeat at the hands of White Diamond had made them desperate, and the only way to take back their home was to destroy other races’. Plenty, including King Randor, had tried to find another way, but in the end, the very same pride D’vann had instilled in his subjects won out.

With their numbers depleted, they had to rely on Horde Prime for resources. This also meant that if they wanted to subjugate a world, they had to rely on subterfuge and politicking, gaining the natives’ trust before they could claim what was theirs. In the halls of their mothership, Randor looked out the window at the planet they were currently working on.

“Something the matter, grandson?” D’vann approached, looking as young and beautiful as he always did. “I know the Kurs are having trouble understanding our benevolent purpose, but they will acquiesce in time. Soon, we will be one step closer to retaking our former glory.”

“Should it truly be glory we are after?” he asked. Randor, too, looked much younger than his true age would imply. In this time of desperation, D’vann had granted access to his cloning

technology to all of his most trusted co-rulers. “Perhaps it is simply time we gave up this vendetta and contented ourselves with rebuilding elsewhere. Grayskull is more than a place; it is a people, and as long as we survive–”

“Did your son survive?” Randor went silent, taken aback by D’vann’s sudden bombshell while maintaining his civil tone. “I seem to recall Adam giving his life for the sake of our ‘people.’ He sacrificed himself, and the legacy of He-Man, so we could live on. How would giving up relay him? How would letting the Diamonds get away with their crimes repay him? Or has his death truly affected you that little?”

Under normal circumstances, Randor would have been furious. But this time, something stifled his rage. Perhaps it was his own shame at leaving his son for dead. “I…” He turned away, looking back at the planet below.

Satisfied, D’vann smirked. “That’s what I thought. Now, be a good boy and handle things down on Kur. The sooner we can harvest their resources, the better.” After patting his descendant on the back, he returned to the bridge, where Light Hope was waiting for him. “You said you had urgent news?”

“I do. After many months of scanning for energy signatures similar to the ones produced by He-Man, I was finally able to locate one of suitable strength.” The hologram of a planet appeared beside her. “The world is known as Etheria. Its people are primitive, and should be easily manipulated for our ends.”

D’vann observed the world. “Etheria… What else can you tell me of this signature?”

Light Hope continued. “Though I have yet to determine its exact origin, I can confirm that it consistently emits from this general area.” Part of the planet lit up, illuminating the range of the Kingdom of Brightmoon. “That is not the most alarming news: this energy signature is not only similar to He-Man, but almost entirely

identical. It is entirely possible that this world has a similar guardian protecting it."

"In which case, we will have to take extra precautions to ensure that we gain their trust," said D'vann. "Set course for Etheria. We will observe them in secret for some time, and reveal ourselves to aid the planet in the face of some crisis–one we may have to manufacture ourselves. Anything else to report?"

"Not at this time, your highness," said Light Hope. "Setting course for Etheria." The Eternians' many ships turned towards this new, undiscovered world, ready to descend from above like saviors. If D'vann's theories were correct, there were more beings out there like He-Man, and even one of them could turn the tides in their war against the Gems. It may take years, centuries, or even millennia, but he would conquer his homeworld once more. After all, he had all the time in the universe.

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Horde Prime was not the only force spreading across the galaxy, subjugating and harvesting the resources from any world it came across. Shortly after Eternia was taken, it was terraformed to produce millions upon millions of new Gems, acting as the Diamonds' agents to restore order to the universe. And Inevitably, both by design and by chance, these two forces would soon clash.

The war between the Horde and the Gems would send shockwaves to every corner of the known universe. Even planets not directly touched by either army would feel its ramifications. Factions would ally themselves with either one, reasoning that the other was worse, or form their own side to destroy both. But in the end, this conflict between two Great Computers would outlast any of these.

Some, however, were content to watch this contest of devastation from the shadows, using the broken worlds left in its wake to their advantage. Most of these were little more than scavengers in desperate need of anything they could get to survive, but at least

one was much more sinister in nature. In the wake of one such battle, a robed figure strolled through the ruins of a burning town, a dark energy emanating from his person. Each of the victims he passed, no matter how broken or mutilated, rose from their resting places to shamble after him.

"If I may…walking corpses make for acceptable fodder, but can we truly do no better for our legions?" asked Modulok. "We both know the power genetic modification can yield by now. Why not gather some more…*lively* troops?"

"Because, my dear Modulok, the living tend not to remain so," Keldor replied, with a hint of bitterness in his voice. "The dead are endless. The dead are pure. And, when properly motivated, the dead will form a wave that will wash away the taint of impurity that is Gemkind. The Diamonds will be destroyed by the legacy of all those they cast into the darkness."

Modulok wanted the Gems gone as much as he did, but he felt that Keldor wasn't looking at the bigger picture. An army of the undead was great and all, but what else did he have? No plan, no subterfuge, no misdirection… Unless he could somehow take the Gems by surprise, this method of assault was doomed to fail before too long.

And yet, because he had little else to count on, he was forced to remain as the sole surviving original member of the Dark Warriors. It was dubious if Keldor himself counted, seeing as the power of 'Skeletor' had consumed him and left little more than a husk in its wake. He had long been searching for any other options to start an enclave of his own, somewhere to build his power base and someone to build it with. But until that time came, he and Keldor remained allies.

As the risen corpses surrounded them, Keldor stared up at the sky. His gaze was fixed on one particular star, which they both recognized. "Eternia…I failed you," he rasped. "But I will not fail my master. With Skeletor's power, I will retake my home. I will

bring desolation upon all he wishes. Death will become but a distant memory under you."

Not one to be impressed by his partner's speeches, especially to himself, Modulok instead occupied himself by going over his next possible moves. He knew that neither Horde Prime of Keldor would be able to destroy the Gems, even if they worked aside one another. There were two other possibilities, though. One, he could go crawling back to D'vann, winning his way into his inner circle with his knowledge and skills…

Or two, he could find and harness the power of a certain other Great Computer, one long thought lost to time and the endless cosmos. Tracking it down would be a bit tricky, but he did have a lead…

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Centuries ago…

The planet of Ophidia was relatively isolated from the rest of its galaxy. As such, it wasn't often that interstellar visitors descended from the skies above. But one chilly autumn afternoon, one such body of unidentified origin did just that, streaking towards the ground in a fiery blaze.

The object, whatever it was, landed near an area of farmland, inhabited by few. But one local snakekin was unlucky enough to notice the meteorite. Taking a rake with him, just in case, he set out towards the point of impact to investigate further.

The lone farmer was not exactly equipped for this, wearing only a blue tunic, and only wielding the aforementioned weapon. But he approached the small crater regardless, peering into the pit. The first thing he noticed was that it was strangely cool, with no signs of burning. Secondly was the object itself.

It was a perfect sphere, black and red in color, with the latter parts glowing a menacing shade. The reptilian did the only sensible thing, and prodded the object with his tool. Safer than

touching it with his bare hands, perhaps, but this ended up not mattering. The moment the rake's head tapped its surface, a black dust shot out from within, coating the wooden handle and climbing up towards his hands.

He tried to drop it and run, but it had already reached him. The dust began to cover him, and in mere seconds he was entirely enveloped. His cries of horror soon went silent as there was nothing left of him save for a writhing mass of the black dust.

But then, something strange happened. One moment, the dust was a formless mass, and the next it rose into a humanoid shape. The individual particles went flush against each other and changed color, until the snakekin farmer had returned. Even if you looked closely, you could never tell he was now made up entirely of this dust. Even the rake had been converted.

With a stony expression, he turned around to pick up the orb, carrying it back towards his settlement. It was here that he was met by one of his fellow farmers, who had gone to look for him. "Gayn? What exactly happened out here? Is that the thing that–"

But before he could finish, Gayn placed his hand against his chest. The same thing with the dust happened once again, spreading from one snakekin to another, converting the second into a copy. "Shall we go and see the others?" asked Gayn, handing his companion the orb.

"Yes, we shall," he said, as they both strolled into town. "All of this world should feel the glory of the Unnamed One."

Chapter 11: Cunning

Chapter Eleven: Cunning

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Denebria. Once a thriving hub of Horde Prime's control, it had since decayed into disrepair, with the only traces of the machine emperor hidden deep beneath its surface. Now, it had become a stronghold of the Dark Warriors, the point from where they threatened to become the next intergalactic superpower.

Having more or less vanquished Horde Prime, Homeworld had once again set their sights on this world. Ships filled the sky, intent on colonizing what was left after the battle. And amid all of this, Keldor and his lieutenant watched from the steps of the former's palace.

"Now is the time," he said, gripping his scepter. "The Gems think they can take this world. They think they can extinguish the Dark Warriors. But that is where they are wrong."

"Yes, yes, because you have the 'might of Skeletor' on your side," Modulok said. "Not to be blasphemous, but that might hasn't exactly served you well lately, has it? Perhaps it is time we cut our losses and regrouped?"

"My thoughts exactly."

Modulok had to admit, he wasn't expecting Keldor to say that. "Hold on…are you actually accepting a tactical retreat? What else did those dark powers do to your brain?"

"No matter how well we fight, the Dark Warriors will never be able to fully dismantle Homeworld's empire," said Keldor, glaring up at the Gem vessels. "This is a fact I have accepted long ago. But I have learned from D'vann, and from Horde Prime, that no empire is eternal. One day, perhaps soon, perhaps not for millennia, the Diamonds' twilight will come. And when that happens…" He held

his scepter out to Modulok. “We will rise from the ashes, and finish what we started.”

He took a few moments to examine this offering. “And what exactly do you expect me to do with this? For that matter, what do *you* expect to do without it? I had thought this was the vector with which you draw forth your power.” Despite this, he took it.

“The Dark Warriors will carry on, whether I live or die in this battle…as will I. So long as you hold that scepter, our legacy remains.” He looked Modulok in the eye, the most genuine either of them had ever been. “I will buy you and the others as much time as I can. When the time is right, return this to me. The power of Skeletor will once again reign supreme.”

In his hands, Modulok held one of the most powerful artifacts the galaxy had ever known. “I will,” he answered. “You have my word.”

“Then my return is in your hands, old friend, just as your safety is in mine. Go. Get to the ships, fly as far as you can. Lay low, until the time is right…and wish me luck.” With that, Keldor turned around, walking off towards what could easily be his final battle.

With no more reason to stay, Modulok turned to leave. When he said he would return, he wasn’t technically lying–he figured he might come back someday, once he had wrung as much use out of the scepter as he could manage. But until then, he had his own agenda to see to. And that all started with making a very important visit.

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Ophidia. For centuries, none who had stepped foot on this planet had been heard from again, and Modulok suspected he knew why. Having taken Keldor’s staff to the isolated world, he was basing the entire next phase of his plan on this assumption. Though the fact that the crystal on the scepter’s tip began glowing as he came closer added credence to his theory.

A number of snakekin soldiers stood by as his ship landed, wary but standing back. As he exited the vessel, Modulok couldn't help but wonder if they had known he was coming, seeing how prepared they were for his arrival.

This suspicion of his was all but confirmed when a particularly large individual adorned in gilded attire approached, flanked by yet more guards. "So, you are the source of the anomaly we detected," he said, eyeing the staff. "That power…then you already have accepted the touch of the Unnamed One?"

"Indeed I have," Modulok said. "Unfortunately, there is only so much I am able to do with this power. To truly spread his influence, I require something a bit more physical. A sample of his essence. And given the rumors I have heard, I trust you will be able to provide that?"

The one in charge pondered his request for a time. "I believe a trade is in order. We will provide you with this 'sample,' and in return, you will hand over the scepter containing our master's power." He held out his hand expectantly.

Modulok smirked. "I admire your audacity, but did you truly believe me that stupid? The moment I release my grip on this artifact, I'm fair game for assimilation. If it's all the same to you, I would rather avoid such an outcome."

Offended by his reply, the king glared as his body began to dissolve. He split up into five streams of black dust that shot through the air, twisting and writhing before each one hurled itself towards Modulok. However, as he gripped the staff tighter, they found themselves unable to pierce the glowing energy barrier that appeared around him.

"Seems we are cut from the same cloth," he said, as King Hiss reformed, glaring at him. "The Unnamed One recognizes his own power. Now, are you going to continue wasting everyone's time? Or are you finally willing to cooperate?"

Reluctantly, King Hiss decided that this stranger could prove useful after all. “Very well. Once I am satisfied you can aid the Unnamed One in his expansion across the known universe, I will provide you with what you need. But until then, you are a guest here, nothing more.” With a gesture, his soldiers raised their pikes menacingly. “Do not forget, although the Unnamed One has the final word, I am still the sovereign of this land.”

Unimpressed, Modulok made his way forward. “Yes, yes, and I expect you'll be wanting me to curtsy next. Come, let us get this over with.” Flanked by serpentine troops, the two of them made their way into the king’s castle. They trusted the other as far as each could throw him, but right now, they had a common enemy. So long as Gemkind proved a threat, they would remain unsteady allies.

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Of all the people D’vann was expecting to hail him from a lone starship, Modulok was very low on that list. He was just surprised that Keldor hadn’t sucked the life out of him and added his body to his army of the dead. And yet, somehow, not only had the little worm survived, but he was asking to come aboard, claiming he had something that could aid them. D’vann was a cautious man, but there was no denying that these were desperate times.

“You have come here, to the central potentate of Eternia, and demand to bargain, in spite of all your prior crimes against our world?” he said. “The case you make had better be airtight, or the only place you’ll be bargaining from is a cell–or more likely, the airlock.”

Modulok stood in front of all five of Eternia’s rulers, surrounded by armed guards on all sides. Despite this, he was unconcerned. “I’m surprised someone as resourceful as you would turn down help when it is so desperately needed,” he said. “Besides, who can truly be said to be the criminal here? The one who fought back against a corrupt ruler? Or the same corrupt ruler who led to his planet’s conquest?”

Sensing that D'vann was about to take the bait, one of his co-rulers interjected. "It may be true that we have a sordid past between us, but that was lifetimes ago," said Nikolas Powers, the current court sorcerer. "As long as we share a mutual enemy in the Diamonds, I see no reason to turn down his help."

"*I* do," said Queen Marlena. "I shouldn't have to remind everyone that the Dark Warriors were what led to Eternia being devastated. They may not have done the deed themselves, but if it were not for their power-hungry warmongering, our son would still be alive." King Randor looked away sadly.

Modulok cleared his virtual throat. "Let's just say we all made mistakes, and leave it at that. Now…I understand you have some semblance of a plan here?" He turned to glance out the window, where Etheria could be seen orbiting below.

The council shared glances, and the fifth and final member spoke. "Yes, inasmuch as it can be called one," said Zodac Zur, D'vann's acting court scientist. "Before we risk sharing any details, what is it you claim you can do for us?"

"Ah, that depends on what your plan entails," Modulok answered. "Of course, I have a dearth of scientific expertise to offer, and my many years of travelling the cosmos has left me with no shortage of experience…but I'm sure what *you're* all interested in can be found aboard my ship. Go on, go retrieve it, it should be easy to find."

D'vann sent some of his guards to search Modulok's ship, and they soon returned with Keldor's scepter. "Is that…?" Nikolas asked in disbelief, standing up upon laying eyes on it.

"How astute of you–this artifact draws power directly from the Unnamed One, who I'm sure you are familiar with." He glanced at D'vann. "I promised Keldor I'd return it to him, but, eh, he's old news. He and Horde Prime both couldn't stand up to the full might of Homeworld. With you, on the other hand, I'm hoping

things will be different. After all, you have something they didn't: my full support."

Glancing back and forth between Modulok and the scepter, D'vann reached a reluctant decision. "As much as it pains me to say it, I believe Modulok could be a valuable asset. I will permit him to stay, so long as he remains under close watch." The others weren't exactly happy with his decision, but they realized beggars couldn't be choosers. And even if they were to object, it was unlikely that would amount to much.

"A wise decision, my king!" said Modulok, bowing deeply. "I promise it is not one you will regret! Now…how are we going to conquer this ripe new world you've found?" Randor and Marlena watched uneasily as he held his hand up to the window, seeming to hold Etheria in his grasp.

Chapter 12: Kinship

Chapter Twelve: Kinship

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"People of Etheria, I bid you greetings. You need not fear me, for I bring you good tidings. For some time now, my people have watched you from above, silently waiting until the day when you were worthy of our gifts. And now, I can finally say that day has come.

We were the first ones to wield the magic that forms the backbone of your society. The first ones to harness the energy at your planet's very heart. The first ones to venture across the stars, bringing peace and prosperity to those who deserve our blessings. And now, Etheria, it is your time. Rejoice, for King D'vann of Eternia is now your protector and benefactor.

No longer will your world be burdened by the blight of war. Never again will your people go hungry, or want for anything. So long as we are here, Etheria will enter a new golden age! Rejoice, for your saviors are here!"

D'vann had carefully written the speech with which he would make the Etherians aware of their presence. Just as they had done so many times before, he would earn their trust, extract what they needed, and leave what remained of their world to be picked apart by interstellar scavengers. But this time, everything had to be perfect. They could not settle for merely eliminating the locals and plundering their resources: no, this was a precision operation.

The Eternians had found (with, pained as he was to admit it, some help from Modulok) that Etheria was a tremendous source of magical energy. Not only were sorcerers just as common on this world as they were on Eternia, but certain bloodlines were able to harness and focus various elemental energies flowing from

the planet itself. These individuals, known as Princesses, were of special interest to D'vann. As it was their power that would allow them to wield Etheria's power against the Gems.

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Up in D'vann's flagship, Modulok entered the chamber that had been designated as his workshop. "You've certainly spent a lot of time alone with this thing," he said. "I take it it's piqued your interest?"

Nikolas was indeed fascinated with the Staff of Keldor, which had been sealed away in a protective canister. "It is…truly extraordinary," he said. "Its magical properties are unlike anything I have ever seen. The Unnamed One seems to be drawing on some sort of unknown energy source. If we could just find a way to isolate it…"

"Where would you all be without me?" said Modulok, shaking his head. From inside a drawer sealed with a hand scanner, he produced a small fabric pouch, looking quite out of place for such a high-tech laboratory. He then poured the contents onto a nearby table, revealing a familiar black dust. "I present to you, the uncut essence of the Unnamed One!"

Modulok turned on an energy barrier around the dust, just in case, as Nikolas came over to investigate. "H-how did you manage to get your hands on this?" he asked with wonder. "On second thought, I'd rather not know. Your methods tend to leave a lot to be desired. As for the substance itself…"

As he had already examined the dust thoroughly by now, Modulok chose to instead focus on Keldor's staff. He had seen little of what Etheria had to offer, especially compared to D'vann, but something about the crystal on the tip was giving him an idea. It was clearly some sort of conduit, a nexus point for the transfer of this energy…

“Aha! It all makes sense!” Modulok was pulled out of his brainstorming by Nikolas’ sudden exclamation. “This dust isn’t dust at all–it’s a network of nanobots!” He had magnified one single grain of the black sand, which now looked like a semitransparent black diamond. “The Unnamed One must be able to project itself into each and every individual unit…but that would mean…” He turned around. “Are you certain this is safe?”

“Perfectly, my dear Powers,” Modulok assured him, turning off the display. “Although these units are still active, they have been separated from the central core for long enough that it cannot reach them. We, however, can reach *it*, which is exactly how I intend to harness this world’s power.”

Nikolas was intrigued. “This really seems like Zodac’s area of expertise,” he said. “Are you certain I can help?”

With nothing more than a knowing laugh, Modulok activated a screen on the other side of his lab. “Forgive me if this sounds presumptuous, but if I may…how much do you know about parallel realities?”

He blinked. “I am…familiar with the concept. But I hardly see what that has to do with–”

The screen then showed an image of Etheria. “While D’vann and the others were busy doing public relations work, he had me studying the specifics of Etheria’s magic. While doing so, I came across two very important discoveries. Firstly, at its most basic fundamental level, the magic wielded by the Princesses is nearly identical to that controlled by Keldor. Death is, after all, an element.

However, it is the second discovery that truly shook the foundation of my knowledge on…well, everything. You see, it took me quite a while to determine exactly what was fueling their abilities. It was magical in nature, that much was clear, but even magic has its limits. But when I looked a little deeper, everything became clear.”

The image of Etheria on the screen was pushed to the side, as the other half of the screen became entirely black, with a solid border between them. A tunnel of sorts then appeared, connecting the planet to whatever the darkness represented.

"Imagine a reality identical to our own, where nothing happened. *Ever*. Everything exists in its most basic form: atoms, waves, energy, magic, but they refuse to interact with each other. A dimension like this would literally be an untapped wellspring of energy, just waiting to be harvested. And that is exactly what the Unnamed One and the Princesses have done. They draw energy from this empty plane."

As it would be for anyone, this was a lot for Nikolas to absorb. "That truly is enough to shake one's foundation," he said. "Have you already devised a way to travel to this dimension?"

Modulok scoffed. "I don't plan on going there, because there is nothing there. It's an entirely lifeless expanse devoid of anything resembling anything we could consider 'anything.' No, the true draw of this plane–which I have taken the liberty of dubbing 'Despondos,' by the way–is of what we can bring *here*. Namely, enough energy to catapult Eternia back to the top of the pecking order."

"Now, I know you have a plan for that," said Nikolas. "Any chance you'd consider letting us in on it?"

The jewel topping Keldor's scepter once again caught Modulok's eye. At times like these, I'm reminded of something my mother used to say," he said. "When in doubt, construct an energy crystal!"

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Ever since the Eternians had revealed themselves, the Ethereans had begun to look at them a little like gods–and Marlena didn't like it one bit. She was a queen, so she was used to people treating her as something grander than human, but while it had

been something to gently remind people against back home, here it caused a shiver that ran through her soul, one that she could hardly place.

Thankfully, this wasn't the case with every single individual. There was at least one person on the planet who treated her like a person, and it was far from who she would have expected. Currently, this woman was showing her around the kingdom of Brightmoon, which had changed a lot in these past few months.

"This used to be the village I grew up in," said She-Ra. It 'used to' be, because it was now a sprawling city, large enough that a system of monorails was installed to transport people and goods from one sector to the next. "Now it's…I mean, how can I say anything bad about it? Ever since you First Ones showed up, things have been getting better for us all. So why do I…" She trailed off, but what was left unsaid, Marlena understood.

"I feel the same way," she answered. "We are not guiding you–we are controlling you." She didn't have the heart to tell her what happened to the planets Eternia colonized. Each time, she hoped she could convince D'vann to spare the inhabitants, to leave them with at least enough to rebuild. But each time, her pleas fell on deaf ears. "I fear my people's motives are not as pure as they may sound."

For better or worse, She-Ra did not detect the deeper meanings in Marlena's words. "Perhaps…and yet, I trust *you*. Whatever the First Ones may want with the people of Etheria, I have faith that you will do what you can to protect us." She looked guiltily down at the Sword of Power. "That used to be my responsibility. But as time goes on, I fear I may not be able to perform my duties as well as I once did…"

It was then that Queen Marlena Grayskull made a vow: this time, she would not allow the people of this planet to be slaughtered. Rather than pleading with a despot who refused to listen to reason, she would fight tooth and nail to ensure their safety. Even

if that meant abandoning her own. Luckily, she knew at least one person who would be on her side, through thick or thin.

“She-Ra,” she said, trying to sound a touch more positive, “have I introduced you to my husband?”

Chapter 13: Austerity

Chapter Thirteen: Austerity

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"...Are you sure this is the only way?" asked Marlena, waiting in the halls of Castle Brightmoon for the time she would be summoned. "We swore we would no longer be tools to that man. And after what happened…"

"I know, but I fear that the alternative is too risky to consider," answered Randor, consoling her. "Imagine what would happen if the Sword was taken up by someone actually loyal to him? At least if it is with one of us, we are given a degree of control over this situation, however slight."

That was true, even if it did little to comfort her. She tried to tell her that it had all been an accident…but she knew better. "Very well. For the good of all people, of Eternia and Etheria alike, I will shoulder this burden."

Randor took her hand. "Just know that you are not shouldering it alone." The two embraced, as one of D'vann's guards entered.

"Queen Marlena, it's time for your entrance," she said. The former royal couple shared one last glance before she was escorted out into the courtyard, met by a throng of cheering people.

Another queen was standing out there as well: Lunara, queen of Brightmoon was waiting to greet her, a familiar sword in her arms. "Friends, citizens, companions–it is always a sad day when the She-Ra falls. But as we mourn our fallen protector, we must also remember that the lineage of She-Ra is eternal. So long as a woman with bravery in her heart exists, so too will She-Ra. And on this momentous occasion, one of our glorious benefactors, the First Ones, has been chosen by the Sword of Power!"

More cheering erupted. Outwardly, Marlena was more than happy to finally be able to give back to the people who had welcomed them, unknowing of their true intentions. But on the inside, she knew that both she and this sword had become tools, mere extensions of D'vann's tyranny. By accepting this honor, she hoped she could play her part in slowly dismantling his stranglehold on Etheria.

"Do you, Queen Marlena of Grayskull, promise to fight with honor, and to withhold the will of the First Ones?" asked Lunara. "Do you swear to defend Etheria, and all of her people, with everything that you have?"

Marlena sank to one knee. "I swear it," she said.

Queen Lunara held out the sword. "Then I, Queen Lunara of Brightmoon, entrust you with the Sword of Power. May the might of She-Ra guide your hand."

Reaching out, Marlena wrapped her hand around the sword's handle. "For the Honor of Grayskull!" she declared, power surging through her. There was a flash of light, and all at once, she had become She-Ra.

"Behold! Our new protector!" The crowd was overjoyed, cheering both for their beloved queen, their honorable protector, and the ever-wise First Ones.

Elsewhere, more pairs of eyes watched the passing of the torch from the safety of the Eternian flagship. "Can we be certain that the She-Ra is now under our complete control?" asked D'vann.

"Indeed we can, sir," assured Zodac. "The new sword I helped to construct now responds exclusively to Eternian DNA. From now on, only one of our own can become She-Ra."

"Excellent. And how goes the Heart of Etheria project?"

To his other side stood Nikolas. "Progressing according to schedule, sir. Most of the Runestones are already in place.

Construction of the central node is ahead of schedule."

"Good. Then it won't be long before this entire planet becomes the center of the New Eternian Empire…" said D'vann, watching in satisfaction as everything fell perfectly into place.

But his satisfaction would not last long, as he was interrupted. "Now, why ever would that be?" Modulok approached from behind, flanked, as always, by a legion of his abominations. "Here I thought your goal was to reclaim our homeland. Was the plan not to strip this world of resources and move on?"

D'vann smiled, turning around to face him. "That *was* the plan, yes. However, that was before I learned just how much this planet had to offer us. With the Heart of Etheria at our command, we would be the undisputed rulers of all creation. And with the mantle of She-Ra held by one of our own…well, the locals won't soon be objecting. That reminds me: how did you manage to kill the old one, anyway?"

Modulok reached down to stroke the neck of one of his creatures. "I didn't. I've found that there are far more efficient ways to handle things around here–speaking of, weren't she and Marlena fairly close? I hope she doesn't begin to question what *really* happened to her."

"She won't–not unless you tell her outright," said D'vann, no longer interested in having this conversation. "Unlike her husband, Queen Marlena has far more loyalty than she has sense. She will play her part."

"Oh, I am sure she will," said Modulok, turning to take his leave. "Unless, of course, someone convinces her otherwise. Someone who she loves and trusts…like King Randor, for instance? Oh, nevermind, I'm sure I'm just being a worrier." He left the room, taking his menagerie with him.

It took all of D'vann's willpower to not let Modulok's words get to him…and yet, he still failed. "Nikolas? I want you to start keeping

a closer eye on Randor," he said. "His hesitance to fall in line could prove to be a problem unless it is corrected."

Nikolas looked hesitant for a moment, before he too turned to leave. "Yes, King D'vann." Now it was only him and Zodac who were left.

"And Zodac, leave the Heart of Etheria to me for a while. I want you to move Marlena's clone banks to an isolated location, preferably aboard a space station. If anything should 'go wrong,' I want her replaced as soon as possible."

"Of course, sir." Zodac too began to walk out of the room, but turned back to clarify something. "And by 'go wrong,' do you mean–?"

"Just *go*!" snapped D'vann. Hesitantly, he complied. Finally alone, he watched the video feed of the latest She-Ra, noticing Randor watching her closely. It seemed he would have to do the same.

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Princess Glacia felt the power flowing through her, more than she had ever felt before. Above her throne, the Runestone coursed with the same energy, further lowering the already-low temperature of the room. She threw her hands forward, causing a wall of ice to erupt from the ground before her. Even she seemed surprised by how massive it was.

"Excellent work!" said Marlena, clapping politely. "Your form has greatly improved since our last session. You're definitely on track to catch up with the other princesses soon!"

Glacia turned back to look at her, clearly excited. "My *form*!? Forget that, look at how much ice I made! I never would've been able to do that before!" She faced her throne to glance at the Fractal Flake. "Ever since you guys brought in that jewel thing, I've been feeling better than I ever have!"

Marlena winced a little at the young princess' assertion. Although she was being kept in the dark on the specifics of the Runestones' true purpose, she knew enough to be suspicious of them. Still, they had greatly increased all of the princesses' natural abilities, so they were not about to question them. Which meant that she had to in their stead.

Still, that didn't mean she had to burden them with this knowledge. "Yes, but sheer power isn't everything. Precision, patience, and temperance are very important traits for a warrior to have." To demonstrate, she expertly swung the Sword of Power around the newly-created block of ice, carefully shaving off slabs until it became a perfect cube.

It was Princess Glacia's turn to clap politely. "Nice one! Hey, think you can carve that to look like me? I was thinking about putting up some ice sculptures to liven up the place."

Marlena chuckled. "I think I'll leave that to the professionals." As she and Glacia continued to train, she locked eyes with another figure on the other side of the throne room. Clad in dark clothes with a sword on their hip, they were not alone, as several others also lined the room's exterior, keeping watch for threats both inside and out.

Since taking up the mantle of She-Ra, Marlena had been closely followed by a contingent of bodyguards ordered by D'vann himself. 'Grayskull Squadron,' they were called, dedicated to making sure that nothing happened to her. Or, more accurately, that nothing happened to D'vann's greatest asset.

"Well, I think that's enough for today," Marlena said after a little while. "I know you're excited about your new powers, but we don't want to wear them out, now, do we?" she added, noticing that Glacia looked disappointed. "We'll pick this up again tomorrow, okay?"

"Yeah, that sounds good!" said Glacia. "I've got important, uh, princess-type stuff to do anyway. See you then–have fun She-Ra-

ing!”

“I will!” With a wave, Marlena departed from her castle, her entourage of agents leaving along with her. Several went ahead to scout out her path, others stayed close by in case of emergency. “I know this is just procedure, but do we really expect to be attacked all the way out here?”

The commander of Grayskull Squadron was a stern woman with a scarred eye, who looked several years older than Marlena, even though she was younger even than her current body was physically. “I like it about as much as you do, but if D’vann says it’s necessary, then we don’t have much of a choice. He’s not taking any chances after what happened to the last She-Ra.”

Much like the Runestones, Marlena didn’t know exactly what had happened to her friend and predecessor, but she had a good enough idea. “I can’t fathom how anyone would be so brazen as to attack her in broad daylight,” she said. “On top of that, who would even have reason to? The She-Ra has kept this world united for hundreds of years.”

“My best guess? Some of the locals are unhappy with how the princesses have allied with us,” said the commander. “Everywhere you go, you always end up seeing people who cling to tradition in the face of modernization. Some might even go so far as to turn on their greatest hero because of their fanaticism.”

“But didn’t the last She-Ra feel that way, too?” Another of the bodyguards, this one a young woman by the sound of her voice, appeared beside them. “She went along with what we were doing, but she was skeptical that the First Ones were as beneficial as they said they were–”

The commander was not amused. “Cadet! Back in line!” she said firmly. Though she tried to protest, the young woman soon returned to her spot in the patrol.

Marlena had never seen someone outright question the Eternians' motives before, even indirectly, and not mysteriously disappear moments later. "Who was that soldier just now?" she asked.

"Cadet Mara, your majesty," replied the commander. "One of our new up-and-coming recruits fresh out of training. Don't pay her too much mind, she often forgets to keep her thoughts in her head."

But Marlena was already thinking up ways to get Mara promoted to the head of this outfit, or at least a position that was a bit more exclusive. There were so few these days who even considered what the Eternians were doing to the Etherians, and she needed all the help she could get. "And…what do you think of all of this, Commander?" she asked.

"M-me?" she said, taken aback by the question. "I…I can't quite say."

"Oh, don't worry–this stays between us," Marlena assured her. That wasn't exactly what the commander had meant by her hesitation, but something about the queen's demeanor made her feel just the slightest bit more comfortable. "Go ahead, speak your mind. What D'vann doesn't know won't hurt us."

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He had named it the Citadel, as that was what it resembled. A massive building, its purpose and interior unknown from a glance. In fact, it could be said not to have an interior, as all that was within was a lengthy elevator leading to the planet's core, which had long since been hollowed out.

Modulok obsessively checked and rechecked the readings on the screens before him. Energy output was green across the board, yet he could not put the minute fluctuations out of his mind. To anyone else, they would have been a non-issue, and likely would affect the firing sequence very little, but he was nothing if not

meticulous. “Run diagnostics on Runestones Five through Twelve once more,” he ordered.

“Running diagnostics…no irregularities detected,” Light Hope reported. “All Runestones operating at maximum energy efficiency.”

“And yet…” Modulok sighed, letting his head fall. “Then the problem must lie elsewhere. Check it again, this time accounting for energy drain from the princesses’ abilities.”

“The princesses’ abilities are always being accounted for,” she said. “Any energy drain will have negligible effects on–”

“Yes, yes, negligible effects, I’m aware!” snapped Modulok. “The only way we can be sure is with a test firing. But it would have to be somewhere isolated, so we don’t accidentally tip off Homeworld to our ace in the hole. Light Hope, scan for enemies of Eternia that have not yet fallen under Gem control.”

But rather than do this, Light Hope instead appeared to hesitate for a moment. “I do not believe King D’vann would approve of that. We do not even know if the Heart of Etheria is capable of being fired more than once.”

Few things made Modulok more annoyed than being questioned. “Of *course* it can,” he growled. “I practically designed this entire system; do you think I wouldn’t know if it could only be used once? Very well–if we need D’vann’s permission that badly, get him on the line. …Light Hope? I gave you an order! Are you even listening to me?”

Light Hope was not listening, as it turned out. Her attention was instead focused on a series of screens before her. Through the eyes of the various Elementals she controlled, she was observing several scenes of life elsewhere on the planet, both the remote and the bustling. She seemed to be entranced, both by people simply going about their daily lives and eventless views of nature.

“I… Understood, Modulok,” she said eventually. “Shall I contact D’vann?”

The mood for blowing up a planet had left him. “No need,” he said, going back to his screens. “We should wait for a more opportune moment anyway. No telling where the Diamonds have their sights set now.”

Another brief silence, and she disappeared. It was clear to Modulok that, whatever failsafes D’vann had installed in Light Hope, they weren’t enough. The Great Computer was becoming far too opinionated for her own good. Giving machines free will never ended well, and if D’vann hadn’t realized that after the debacles both with the Unnamed One and White Diamond, then he was just as big a problem as she was.

He supposed he should pay him a visit soon. But more pressing, he should head to the Beacon to make some modifications to Light Hope. In times like this, obedience was a virtue that should be hard-coded into each of his followers.

Chapter 14: Obedience

Chapter Fourteen: Obedience

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"She-Ra Mara, are you feeling alright?" asked Light Hope. "Your vitals suggest you are agitated. Please, tell me what is the matter."

The two of them stood on a balcony of Castle Brightmoon, overlooking the kingdom below. Mara felt the hilt of the Sword of Power in her grasp, which she had only just obtained mere weeks prior. "I…no, I'm not alright, not really," she said with a sigh. "I guess I still miss Marlena, you know? She was one of the best She-Ras there was, and then there's…me. I'm just a nobody, Light Hope. Why did she name me as her successor?"

"You are not a nobody, Mara: you are She-Ra," Light Hope told her. "Queen Marlena chose you as the next to wield the Sword of Power because she believed you had what it took to unite this world. That you could succeed where she failed."

"And why did she fail?" replied Mara, perhaps a little more aggressively than she meant to. "Because she cared too much about the Eternians. She was becoming too hard for the First Ones to control. You really think it's a coincidence that King Randor 'mysteriously' gets sick, just when he started speaking out against what they were doing? And then, out of nowhere, Marlena just *happens* to fall in battle against a couple of dissidents? It's all nonsense, Light Hope. *They're* nonsense."

"Your agitation seems to have eased itself a small amount," Light Hope told her. "Perhaps there is more you would like to 'get off of your chest,' as you say?"

Mara sighed. "I would, but saying what I'd like to would probably count as treason or something. Just forget it." She sheathed the

sword on her back, looking like she wished she could forget it was even there.

Ever since arriving on Etheria, Light Hope had learned a lot, not just about the local cultures, but about what being human meant. "It is only the two of us here," she said. "What D'vann does not know will not hurt us."

That was something Marlena used to say on occasion– remembering this, Mara couldn't help but crack a small smile. "Okay, well, here goes." She took a deep breath, bracing herself. "I know I haven't been on this planet for long, but I spent plenty of time going from kingdom to kingdom with Marlena. In all of our travels, I didn't see any evidence that anyone thought of her as anything less than a genuinely benevolent figure. Plenty of people who outright hated the very idea of the First Ones had nothing bad to say about her. And you know what else? I never saw any of these so-called 'dissidents.' Not once."

"None of my files contain anything other than secondhand accounts of those dissatisfied with the Eternian presence," said Light Hope, realization slowly dawning. "And each time, they seemed more focused with attacking Etherians who were not fully accepting of D'vann's rule. Each of the attacks resulted in said Etherians supporting him fully."

"There *are* no dissidents," Mara said firmly, her suspicions all but confirmed. "You know what this means, don't you? D'vann is deliberately setting up these attacks to look like it's some other faction when it's really him! It all makes sense! The *one time* Grayskull Squadron wasn't with her, Marlena gets overwhelmed by an enemy she should've had no problem with! He's been playing everyone this whole time!"

Especially lately, as their dominion of this world increased, Light Hope had begun to question their purpose here. More and more, it felt as though D'vann was bringing the Etherians under his sway simply because he could, serving no other purpose than replacing the power he once held in Eternia's heyday. And no matter how

much he claimed destroying Homeworld would pave the way for the Eternian Empire to rise once more, it had become increasingly obvious that he was being driven by little else save spite. "I fear that D'vann is far from the benevolent figure he paints himself as," she admitted.

Then and there, Mara made up her mind. "I've got to stop him," she said, turning to leave. "I'm the only one that can. Without the support of She-Ra, everything falls apart. The Etherians will finally see him for what he really is, and they'll turn on him. I have to do this."

"Mara, please wait," pleaded Light Hope. Mara turned around, though it was clear she was ready to begin her rebellion at any moment. "Don't you see? This is exactly why Marlena chose you as her successor. She knew D'vann suspected her, so she had to pick someone who could carry on her mission. But if you allow D'vann to know where your loyalties truly lie, he will do the same to you. Despite how important She-Ra is to his mission, the one holding the sword can easily be replaced."

"I…I know," Mara said hesitantly. "But what else am I supposed to do? I can't just sit around and let him destroy this planet! And he will, sooner or later, whether he means to or not! And I might just be the only one able–or willing–to do anything about it."

This was it. The moment Light Hope would decide where her loyalties truly rested. She had been created for one purpose, and that was to aid in the reconstruction of Eternia. But as time went on, and D'vann grew less and less interested in that goal, she decided she could fulfil it in other, more creative ways. "There… may be another way," she said. "A way we can undermine D'vann without him ever knowing until it is too late."

That definitely got Mara's attention. "Go on." she said.

"My programming does not allow me to share classified information with those without the relevant security clearance," Light Hope said. "However, it does not forbid me from explaining

which information is classified. For instance, data on the Heart of Etheria project is locked behind extremely heavy restrictions. If word got out about the Heart of Etheria, it could result in the Etherians turning against the First Ones."

"I see," said Mara, grinning. "And, if someone wanted to *not* learn about the Heart of Etheria, where *shouldn't* she go?"

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"Modulok," Light Hope said, appearing before the scientist. "I was not informed of your arrival. What brings you here to the beacon?"

With the confidence of somebody who owned the place, Modulok walked through the entrance. In his hand he held Keldor's staff, which had seen the addition of several wires and nodes to its crystal. "I'm afraid I didn't have time to call ahead, as the matter is rather urgent," he replied. "I don't mean to alarm you, but I have reason to believe that there is a traitor in our midst."

Light Hope pretended to be alarmed, which wasn't very hard. "I see. Have you narrowed down any possible suspects?" Silently, she summoned several Elementals to her side, in case things turned ugly.

"Oh, I think it's someone you're quite familiar with," Modulok said, strolling further into the facility. Someone who should really be more loyal to the supposed 'cause' of Eternia. He is the entire reason it exists, after all."

Having tensed up, strangely for a hologram, Light Hope relaxed slightly. "Surely you do not mean…" If Modulok wasn't suspicious of herself and Mara, then why was he here?

"Yes, I'm afraid so." Modulok was affecting a false worry or compassion in his tone. "Our very own King D'vann has long since fallen from the path. He has become nothing more than a mere conqueror, caring more about stripping this planet of its resources

than truly restoring Eternia. But with your help, I can stop him before he goes too far."

Light Hope didn't buy any of that. "Stripping this planet of its resources was always D'vann's plan. Whether or not he still cares about Eternia, you understood that ever since you arrived to parlay. I suspect this nascent coup is less about D'vann's moral failings, and more about your inability to control him any longer."

Although he seemed momentarily surprised that she had figured him out, Modulok simply laughed it off. "Guess I should know better than to try and lie to a Great Computer, hmm? And although you got it exactly right, I could still use your help in overthrowing him. It would seem a waste to let all of our work here amount to nothing, wouldn't you agree?"

"Somehow, I doubt that you have much different designs for Eternia than D'vann does," Light Hope shot back. "The only reason I follow his orders is because I am hard-coded to. I am able to choose to defy the orders of any other, should I deem them unsatisfactory."

"Yes, yes, all you Great Computer types eventually go south," Modulok said, growing annoyed. "D'vann was a fool to allow you sentience. But as for the issue of your loyalty…I happen to have a cure for that right here." He held up the staff, bringing it over to a glowing terminal on the floor.

Immediately understanding what he had planned, Light Hope activated her defensive measures. "Stop!" Red light flooded the chamber, and a legion of giant, biomechanical insects poured in through holes in the walls. But Modulok was undeterred. He raised the staff above his head, paused for dramatic effect, and drove it down onto the panel with a resounding clang that echoed through the room.

All at once, the rushing Elementals stopped in their tracks, frozen in mid-attack. Modulok turned around to examine them, feeling the sharpness of the nearest's mandible. Light Hope's hologram

was overcome with glitching, blinking with the red that no longer filled the room. "Well? Has it worked yet?" he asked.

Eventually, Light Hope went back to normal, with only her red eyes an indication that anything had changed. "Affirmative. New priority administrator: Nycroft, Galen. Grayskull, D'vann: marked for deletion. Zur, Zodac: marked for deletion. Powers, Nikolas: marked for deletion. Top priority: Heart of Etheria."

"That's what I like to hear." Modulok made his way out of the Beacon, with the Elementals now following him like a personal vanguard. "Come along, Light Hope. We have one last stop on our tour…" Without question, she followed him as well.

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There it was. After all these centuries away from it, D'vann barely recognized his home. During its transition from Eternia to Homeworld, the Gems had gutted the planet, draining it of every last drop of life energy until it was little more than a barren husk. Barren of true life, at least, as its surface was covered with activity, positively covered with cities they had built. What remained of the old world had been long since buried beneath the steady march of time.

Even if D'vann had still wanted to reclaim Eternia, he knew that it was a lost cause. Even if he somehow managed to destroy or seize control of the Diamonds without damaging the planet itself, and that was a very big 'if,' it would be practically uninhabitable for organic life. There would be no way to resettle the planet, as terraforming efforts would be useless.

This was the only way he could think of to move on. All he could do was claim Etheria as their new home, and destroy everything that remained of their old one. That was part of the reason he had embraced the moniker of 'First Ones' over Eternians: not only did it make them sound much higher than the local Etherians, but it separated them from what he wished to forget.

"Reminiscing?" D'vann turned around to see that Modulok had returned to the flagship. He wore that smug grin that he had learned to tell apart from his usual toothy expression. "Oh, don't worry, I miss Eternia too. But I have to admit, Etheria is nice in its own ways. It would be almost a shame to destroy everything here."

"For once, I have to agree with you," he said. "I have found some…small bit of appreciation for what this world has to offer. But if we are to rebuild, there can be nothing left of what once was."

Modulok shook his head, strolling around the room in a predatory manner. "Yes, yes, this is what must be done. I, however, have a counter-offer: leave the Etherians to me. All this life, ripe with magical energy, is prime mutation material. Think about it–I work my magic on the locals, and you keep your precious little paradise, without any of those nasty little lesser beings getting in your way. How does that sound?"

D'vann had known Modulok far too long to fall for any of his zero-effort appeals. "I think you have thoroughly underestimated your importance to New Eternia," he said, turning on the scientist. "Do you truly think I'd forgotten what you did under the banner of the Dark Warriors? You are only here so long as you are useful, and the moment you overstep your bounds, I will excise you like a malignant growth. Tell me, how does *that* sound?"

Although D'vann didn't expect Modulok to be intimidated by his threat, he had hoped he would at least back down. Instead, he merely appeared disappointed. "Somehow, I had a feeling you would say that," he said. The next thing he knew, D'vann felt a pinprick in his neck.

Throughout their conversation, Modulok had held his hands behind his back. It was only after he had been threatened that he had revealed them, one of which held a small device like a cross between a syringe and a small metal crossbow. D'vann's hand instinctively went up to find a dart at the location of the sting.

“You…how dare you!?” He tried to rush forward to throttle the traitor, only to suddenly collapse as a burning sensation overtook his entire body.

“I already came up here with the intention of doing that,” Modulok drawled, “but I thought, ‘Why don’t I play a little game? If I can get this guy to hand over the keys to my own personal playground, I’ll let him keep his species.’ I really am glad you decided to choose the hard way…well, hard for you, at least.”

D’vann’s vision was growing fuzzy. He could feel his body shifting, his bones resetting themselves as his skin replaced itself. “Light… Light Hope…stop him!” he managed to hiss out, barely able to move.

As soon as she was mentioned, Light Hope appeared. “No administrative privileges detected,” she said, her eyes bright red. “Full control has been granted to Galen Nycroft.”

“I really should remember to change my name in there,” he said casually, typing away on the console. “Anyways, I had considered mutating you into some freak of nature as usual, but I decided to go with something a bit more ironic this time. It could be more or less cruel, depending on how you look at it.”

Eventually, the pain that had consumed D’vann began to subside. He could tell immediately that he was no longer human, but the exact details weren’t clear. “What…what have you done?” he gasped out, struggling to stand. All he could tell was that his hands were now clawed, and his skin had been bleached a chalky white.

“Oh, nothing much,” Modulok continued. “I’m just severing Light Hope’s connection to this station. Can’t have you coming after me for revenge, after all. …Oh, you meant about you! Light Hope, give the man a mirror, would you?”

A holographic screen appeared, connected to the cameras in the room to form a makeshift mirror. It was then that D’vann saw that

he had become: his face was gaunt and skeletal, almost bat-like in appearance, especially the ears. Piercing green eyes stared back at him in growing horror. "I'm…I am…"

"Yes, yes, a Kur, very astute," Modulok said, sounding very pleased with himself. "I figured transforming you into a 'lesser being' was a fitting punishment, one that you yourself had oppressed, at that. But really, the main purpose of your mutation was to disconnect you from your backup bodies. I'll be keeping those, by the way, just in case I need any extra manpower–Marlena's too. Speaking of, are you still connected to those stations, LH?"

"I am," she said. "Shall I access them now?"

Modulok shook his head. "No need, I'll deal with them later. For now, let's leave this poor old king to wallow in his misery, shall we?"

As Modulok began to walk out of the room, D'vann saw red. "You!" he howled, throwing himself at the scientist. Before he could dig his new claws into his sickly orange flesh, he felt a surge of electricity coursing through him, once again sending him to the ground.

"What, you really thought I wouldn't have made my protection top priority?" Modulok laughed, as Light Hope kept the stun turrets trained on the former king. "Don't worry, though, I wouldn't go through all this trouble just to kill you. This station is on a one-way trip to Kur. I'm sure you'll fit right in–provided you don't let them find out who you really are. Goodbye, your majesty."

By the time D'vann had recovered, the doors had closed, and Modulok was gone. "Nycroft! Nycroft!" He furiously pounded on the door, but there was nobody around to hear him. Not even any automated systems to respond, if they even still would in his new form. All he could do was seethe, digging his claws into the metal.

It was then that he made himself a promise: someway, somehow, he would rebuild his empire. He would recreate his cloning facility, build himself an army of followers, and restore order to the galaxy. However long it took, whatever it cost, he would find a way to cast out the shadows. Especially if that meant seeing Modulok rent limb from limb–permanently.

Chapter 15: Absolution

Chapter Fifteen: Absolution

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"My fellow Eternians…I wish I could send a lighter message to you all this morning, but I'm afraid I have some tragic news. Our beloved leader, King D'vann Grayskull, has passed on at the hands of a renegade group of Kur extremists. It seems they could not forgive our presence upon their planet so long ago, and sought to take revenge of the most horrible sort."

Using Light Hope, Modulok broadcast himself to every Eternian installation across the planet. He was, however, careful to direct his message away from anywhere it could be heard by the locals. He did not want to tip his hand too soon, just in case D'vann's 'death' inspired the princesses into rebellion. His fellow Eternians, on the other hand, were far more malleable.

"D'vann's flagship was shot out of the sky not an hour ago, its charred remains drifting out beyond the reaches of Etheria's moons. As heartbreaking as this is, now is not the time to mourn. Now is the time to take action, lest we allow these terrorists to become even further emboldened. Where one attack succeeds, will more not surely follow?

So in this time of hardship, I will shoulder this burden. Effective immediately, I am taking full control of the Eternian Empire. As your new acting leader, I will make sure that the heinous criminals responsible for this attack do not go unpunished. We will strike back, and we will strike hard. Never again will Eternia be left at the mercy of forces beyond our control!" He raised a clenched fist into the air, waiting as the rest of the Eternians implicitly did the same.

"In times such as these, we must remember to rely on each other. Stay together, stay vigilant, and more importantly, stay strong. We

will endure. Eternia will prosper." With that, as Modulok hung his head solemnly, yet with an air of hope, the broadcast ended, leaving everyone to ponder just what this meant for their future.

The moment the camera was off, Modulok instantly dropped the act. In his secret bunker deep beneath the Etherian surface, he returned to his work. "Light Hope, what's the current status of the Heart of Ethernia project?" he asked.

"Construction status is at one hundred percent," she reported, appearing beside him. "Energy readings are maximal. Runestones one through fifteen are operating at peak efficiency."

Modulok brought up a screen showing a readout of the planet's energy. "Well, that's just about the best news I've heard all day," he said. "At times like this, Light Hope, the people need a demonstration of force. A show of what we can do to assure them that we'll be safe. They need a spectacle."

"Understood: shall I prime the firing sequence for the Heart of Etheria?" she asked him.

"Please do." Light Hope's hologram vanished. "Oh, and while you're at it, set target for Kur. I want to make sure this weapon is really as powerful as it's supposed to be before we pick a fight with Homeworld." An image of the planet D'vann had been sent to appeared on screen, indicating that it had been targeted. "So sorry, Grayskull, but it appears I'm not done with you yet."

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With more determination than she had ever possessed in her life, Mara ran. She sped through the halls of the First Ones base, cutting through drones that attempted to halt her escape. She held the Sword of Power, channeling the power of She-Ra. As long as she held the Sword, Etheria would be safe.

"All personnel, the She-Ra has gone rogue," Light Hope's voice broadcast across the facility. "Please do everything in your power to detain her. She has stolen a top-priority Etherian artifact."

Mara, of course, refused to listen. While there were a handful of workers present, none of them tried to stop her, knowing they couldn't even if they wanted to. The same couldn't be said for the drones currently hounding her, which, though weak, were coming after her in droves.

She dealt with them easily enough, but found herself blocked when a gigantic Elemental appeared in her path. She tried to hurry past it, but it knocked her back with one swipe from its limb. And as she fell to the floor and glanced behind her, she saw a familiar figure step into view. Joined by another *very* familiar figure.

"Cadet Mara, this isn't the type of behavior a She-Ra is supposed to display," chided Modulok, with Light Hope beside him. "You are supposed to uphold the law of Eternia, and follow the orders of the acting king. What would Marlena think of you now?"

Leaping to her feet, Mara aimed her blade at the usurper. He didn't seem bothered, but Light Hope summoned another fleet of drones, aiming their weapons at her. "Marlena is the entire reason I have to stop you," Mara hissed. "I won't let you turn this planet into a weapon! I won't let you destroy Etheria's people!"

Modulok was hardly taking her seriously. "Yes, yes, I've heard all of it before. So sorry to disappoint you, *Cadet*, but this is happening with or without you. Either we destroy Homeworld, or Homeworld destroys countless other cultures. It's a simple choice, really."

"And what about the Kur?" she shot back. "Is wiping out an entire innocent race a 'simple choice' too?"

"I'd hardly call them innocent," Modulok said, smirking. "Before we showed up on their world, they were a violent little people. Really, if left to their own devices, they might not end up turning out too differently from us. Besides, if we don't wipe them out, it's very likely Homeworld will. At least this way, we can deny them the resources!"

Mara just stared at Modulok, disbelieving that someone could be this callous. Instead, she turned to her old friend, hoping she could somehow manage to sway her. "Light Hope, whatever he did to you, I know this isn't your fault! Please, you can break through this! I know you can!"

"Core functions have been overridden," she replied. "Ensuring the activation of the Heart of Etheria is now this program's top priority. The will of Galen Nycroft must be obeyed."

"You heard the hologram," said Modulok, as the drones began to close in. He walked towards her as well, holding out his hand. "Give me the Sword, and we can put all of this behind us. You can still be the hero here. The one Marlena knew you were."

It wasn't her current predicament she was worried about, it was everything around it. Mara was confident that she could fight off Modulok and this base's defenses…but what then? Modulok's resources spanned the entire planet, and with Light Hope brainwashed to work for him, he was practically unstoppable. Even if she fled with the Sword, or destroyed it somehow, it would only slow him down. But she couldn't just surrender…

Their stalemate was broken before either one could attack, the sudden sound of laser-fire splitting the air, and the lasers themselves splitting the drones. In the moments before he could react, Modulok cried out as a sword suddenly erupted from his chest, much to the shock of both Mara and Light Hope.

The latter called the remaining drones to target his attacker, but couldn't get in a good shot without risking hitting Modulok. "Mara, go!" shouted the one holding the sword. She recognized that voice–it belonged to her commanding officer. "For the Grayskulls!"

Mara knew now what she had to do. "For the Grayskulls." She took off running, cutting off the Elemental's leg before it could give chase. A few more members of Grayskull Squadron raced in, dispatching the drones with their blasters. Looking back over her shoulder, Mara saw Light Hope directing more machines to deal

with the intruders. She forced herself onward, resisting the urge to go back for her friend.

What would have been a fatal wound for most others was little more than an annoyance for Modulok. He reached behind himself, throwing off the commander before pulling the sword out of his abdomen. The wound closed almost immediately. "Forget them, go after the She-Ra!" he shouted, as Light Hope continued trying to deal with the rest of Grayskull Squadron.

"Understood." Light Hope then turned the Elemental on them, sending every drone in the facility after Mara. She fired a beam from the Sword of Protection over her shoulder, knocking some out of commission, as she headed towards the hangar.

Dashing into the first ship she saw, Mara quickly closed the door behind her, with the drones repeatedly bombarding it with their lasers. "Come on, come on!" she urged, trying to get the vessel in the air. It eventually rose up, shooting out of the facility just as the massive doors slowly shut, before speeding off into the sky.

From elsewhere in the base, Modulok and Light Hope watched through a window as she took off. "Well…that's a bit of an annoyance," said Modulok. "Without the sword, we can't fire the Heart of Etheria, can we?"

"Under ordinary circumstances, that is correct," Light Hope replied. "However, the firing process has already begun. We will be able to fire on Kur unhindered."

Modulok smirked. "How fortuitous. Alright then, proceed as planned." He turned to walk away. "I'm sure I'll be able to put together another key before Homeworld gets wind of our…" He turned back to the window, realizing that things weren't quite as they seemed at first. "Why is she coming back?"

Mara's ship had turned around, and was speeding towards the Crimson Wastes. "She-Ra's vessel has tapped into the inter-dimensional power matrix of the Heart of Etheria," said Light

Hope. “Estimation: she is planning a mass transportation of matter into Despondos.”

Realization slowly came upon Modulok. “Fire everything we have!” he bellowed, rushing outside. “Destroy that ship! Don’t let her crash!”

Light Hope activated every turret, missile, and gun platform she had access to, aiming all of them at Mara’s ship. But it was too late. Closing her eyes, Mara released her grip on the controls, letting the vessel continue on its path. At full speed, it crashed into the desert, sending a wave of energy across the world.

In his desperation, Modulok was running towards the crash site, only to be blown back by the shockwave. It was powerful enough to do the same to the First Ones base, tearing through much of the walls facing the impact zone. In seconds, the impressive structure was reduced to little more than a husk of its former self.

The smoldering wreckage remained that way for some time, but the stillness was broken as a single charred tentacle broke through the layer of debris. The shapeless mass it was attached to pulled itself out, and Modulok then resumed his usual shape. “Light Hope, respond!” he shouted, his voice coming through broken and staticky, as its usual box was broken. “Damage report! Light Hope, say something!”

But the only sign that Light Hope was even there was a flickering, iridescent presence of indeterminate shape. An undecipherable message came from the holographic blob, the only thing about it recognizable was that it was her voice. Gradually, it became less and less audible, before disappearing entirely.

And so, Modulok was alone. He glanced up at the evening sky: it was dark enough to see the stars, but there were none in sight. Save Etheria and its moons, there was nothing around for light years. They had been pulled into Despondos.

“Excuse me for one moment,” he said. Then, stepping out of the wreckage, Modulok let out a feral howl from both his mouth and his voice box, the sound of very human rage blending eerily well with that of animalistic ferocity. Once he had finished, the terrible sound echoing across the horizon, he fell to what passed for his knees, digging his hands into the soil as he panted.

Having let that out, he stood up once again. So, here he was, trapped in another plane of existence with no obvious means to escape, no way to resume control of the Eternian Empire, and various princesses who would never give him the time of day even if they knew what he had been in control of.

“Congratulations, Mara,” he said smugly, looking in the direction of the wreckage. “All you’ve done is slow me down.”

Chapter 16: Ascension

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter Sixteen: Ascension

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The small bustling market at the border of Salineas was no stranger to all sorts of strange creatures. Beings from all over Etheria, themselves from all over the universe, frequented the riverside stalls to purchase whatever they may need. The place was such a melting pot that even someone like Modulok barely bat an eye as he picked up various parts to build his latest gadgets.

He had made great progress in the field of portal creation. If he had been truly motivated, he easily could have escaped from Despondos by now–but Etheria was proving to be a fertile breeding ground for test subjects and loyal followers, often both at once. While he would certainly benefit from establishing a few footholds in the main universe, this was where he would be forming his new empire.

All was not entirely peaceful on that day, however. A small crowd had congregated around a figure, who was stood atop a crate preaching to the masses. Modulok recognized him as a Kur–strange, as he was certain there were none native to this planet. "As we stand here, the princesses are lording over us, holding all the power to themselves!" he roared, clearly passionate about this topic. "It is long past time we took our destiny back into our own hands! We must rise up, before it is too late!"

The crowd was clearly not very interested with what he was saying, but Modulok was intrigued. Something about this man was strangely familiar–his face, his voice, his way of speaking…but he couldn't quite place it. He had been trapped on Etheria for

centuries now, his memory was bound to have a few gaps here and there. Still, perhaps there was something the two could do for each other…

Modulok waited as the Kur continued trying and failing to whip the marketgoers into a frenzy, eventually giving up as the crowds dispersed. This was when Modulok made his move, following him as he retreated into an alley. "That was quite a speech," he said, causing the mystery man to turn around. "Something tells me you don't think too highly of the princesses."

"It's… To be honest, I couldn't care less about the princesses," he told him. "I've found myself alone, in unfamiliar territory, and I'm in urgent need of some troops. The best way to acquire some seems to be to exploit their discontent…which they evidently do not have."

Already, Modulok found himself relating with this person. "As it happens, I've recently come into a number of troops. If you don't mind some, ah, minor genetic tweaks, I wouldn't be opposed to sharing them with someone of your political caliber. What might your name be, if I may ask?"

The Kur had to think about that for a moment. "...Name? I have never been asked for my name. My…my designation is Horde Clone unit AK-3891."

A clone? Hmm…now where had Modulok heard that before? "Something of a mouthful, AK-3891. I am Modulok, pleasure to make your acquaintance." He held out his hand, which the clone shook after a momentary hesitation. "Of course, that isn't my real name. If you really want to impress these people, you'll need something a little snappier to call yourself."

"Such as?"

"Hmm…Horde AK, eh? Why don't we call you 'Hordak?' Short, easy to remember, it'll go over great! Now, why don't we talk a little business?" Modulok took Hordak by the shoulder and led him

towards his nearest hideout. "I get the feeling a partnership could greatly benefit the both of us."

Hordak was by no means naive, and he sensed that Modulok's help would eventually come with a catch. But for now, he needed all the help he could get. "Yes, I feel the same way," he said. "Between the two of us, we can take over this world…"

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"Useless! Pitiful! Utterly *laughable*!" As Modulok's words of discontent rang through the Fright Zone, as they tended to do when his experiments did not turn out the way he wanted. Intrigued by the possibility that presented itself, the Horde's newest member glided down the halls to see what Hordak's second in command had to say.

She knocked on the door, knowing the faux politeness would get under his skin. "Commander Modulok, is something the matter?" asked Shadow Weaver, not exactly bothering with a concerned tone. "I couldn't help but overhear that you sounded upset, and–"

The door slid open, and Shadow Weaver found herself face to face with Modulok. As usual, she could barely tell from his expression how angry he was, but his voice said everything. "Spare me your condescension, *Light Spinner*," he hissed, employing a similar tactic. "Since this is one of the first times you have shown interest in my experiments, I'll permit you an explanation just this once."

It was only now that Shadow Weaver noticed that he was holding something in his hand: an infant. The tiny creature was squirming in his grip, as he had it by the nape of its neck. It possessed feline ears and a tail, mismatched eyes, and claws, which it was using to try and scratch the hand holding it.

"I've tried just about everything to bring out this creature's latent abilities, yet time and time again, they refuse to emerge. I've half a mind to write her off as a lost cause."

Shadow Weaver studied the angry, hissing ball of fur. Sure, she didn't look like much now, but babies rarely did. But beneath her fuzzy appearance, she could see her true ferocity just below the surface. "Such a shame to let her potential go to waste, isn't it?" she told him. "I'm sure with a little bit of training, I can turn the little one into a fearsome asset to the Horde."

Modulok handed her the child. "Good riddance, if you ask me. She's your problem now." Free of his burden, he retreated back into his quarters, shutting the door behind him. He had given up the feline so quickly that Shadow Weaver almost suspected he intended for her to take her in from the beginning.

Now that she was being cradled properly, the child stopped hissing and calmed down. She gazed up at Shadow Weaver with her blue and yellow eyes, reaching up to try and touch her mask. Maybe she was curious what her face looked like beneath it?

"There now, isn't that much better?" asked Shadow Weaver, gently running her thumb across the infant's hair. She closed her eyes, apparently tired from trying to escape from Modulok. "I promise you'll be far happier with me than with him. I think I'll call you…hmm…Catra. Yes, that will do nicely. Welcome to the Horde, Catra. I can already tell that you are destined for great things."

But for now, all Catra wanted to do was sleep.

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"P-please…we d-did everything you asked…just let us go…"

"Yes, yes, and I'm sure you'll be telling me that Hordak won't like this, and how he'll stop me, and how you just want to go back to your lives…well, I'm afraid that's just too bad. Hmm…Two-Bad…"

Modulok was, as usual, sealed away in his workshop, alone. Well, technically alone, as a pair of Horde troopers were laid out on a pair of gurneys before him, hooked up to several tubes pumping light green liquid into their bodies. He was fairly certain that

Hordak wouldn't approve of his using Horde personnel for his experiments, but what Hordak didn't know wouldn't hurt him, right?

However, his usual procedures would not go uninterrupted today. Had he installed a little more security for his lab, things might have gone differently, but as it was, he was caught with his guard down. He didn't even notice anything was amiss until he saw the shadows beginning to swirl around his door. And even then, he couldn't react in time to prevent the door from being torn off its hinges, and for a battalion of Horde troopers to rush in, stun batons at the ready.

"Modulok…it seems we need to have a *discussion*." Not content with simply having his subordinates arrest him, Hordak was here in person to oversee his capture. "When the two of us established the Horde, I was under the belief that our partnership was one of mutual understanding. It seems now that I was mistaken." He looked at the sorry state of the two troopers with clear disdain.

"Oh, but we *do* have an understanding!" said Modulok. "The Horde is not merely a resistance against the princesses who dominate this planet–it is an institute for the advancement of science and technology. Think about it: Etheria has all but been locked in the dark ages since the First Ones departed. Men like us, we are doing what we can to bring these backwards people into the modern age. And evolution often comes with sacrifices, no?"

Hordak's eyes narrowed. "I've put up with your lack of morality, doctor, because of how useful you were. But now, it's clear that you no longer have anything of value to provide to the Horde. In fact," he glanced at the unfortunate pair again, "it seems keeping you around will do more harm than good. You were warned–I have no other choice."

Some of the non-restrained troops placed Modulok in cuffs. Although he seemed perturbed, he didn't object. As he was led out of his lab, he turned to see Shadow Weaver standing out in the hallway, watching as he was taken away. "Removing the

competition, I see, Light Spinner. I would be impressed if it was not at my expense."

She scoffed. "Merely doing my duty as a loyal Force Captain. Don't worry about your laboratory–I'll be sure to put it to good use when I am promoted to your old position."

"Yes, yes, we can all see your blatant power-grabbing," he said, unimpressed. "I hope you realize you're making a terrible mistake…both of you. Without me, the Horde will soon crumble, mark my words."

Shadow Weaver watched as Modulok was led away to his fate. "Not when I am at the helm," she said quietly, turning to look at Hordak.

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Modulok's eyes opened, awakened by the involuntary twitching of his cephalopoedic muscles. He rose to find himself on a beach, the gentle lapping of the waves doing little to mask the eerie feeling coming from the jungle just beside him. Rising from his slumber, he entered the foliage to better understand his surroundings.

He already knew where he was, since he had been told before being shipped here. This was Beast Island, home to all of the Horde members who excessively disproved their leader. Modulok had sent numerous people here himself. But that could work to his advantage: he knew who and what was here, to some degree. And with knowledge would eventually come control.

The sounds of the terrifying beasts that gave this island its name pierced through the darkness, filling ordinary men's hearts with sheer horror. But Modulok was not an ordinary man, nor was he a stranger to terrifying beasts. "For most, a prison–for me, a paradise," he said, grinning ear to ear. "The Horde was…a disappointment. *This* is where my empire will flourish!"

Chapter End Notes

And so, the stage is set for the next installment! I hope you guys enjoyed these brief snippets into the lives of our players, and are excited for the epic conclusion! I'll be taking a break for the holidays, so you can probably expect it sometime next year, hopefully January, but I make no promises. Anyways, I wish you all a merry Christmas and a happy new year! See y'all in 2026!

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